

75 Days in the Strait of Hormuz

An Indian merchant navy captain recalls being trapped deep inside the war zone, with his crew pushed to breaking point

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magazine

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ET WEALTH ON MONDAY

Where's my home?

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PoK Unrest Vindicates Sheikh Abdullah's Choice, says J&K CM

Jammu and Kashmir chief minister Omar Abdullah said the ongoing violent protests in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir vindicated his grandfather Sheikh Abdullah's decision to fight the tribal raiders who invaded the region in 1947 and join India. Hakeem Irfan Rashid reports.

Sonia Tried to Obstruct National Song Rendition: BJP; Cong Denies Claim

The BJP accused Congress MP Sonia Gandhi of trying to obstruct the rendition of the national song, 'Vande Mataram', at her party's Independence Day function. The Congress refuted the claim, saying her gestures were aimed at getting a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge.

AI-led Matchmaking Apps Getting All the Investor Love

These startups use AI to narrow choices by creating user profiles based on dating history & personality; traditional dating platforms lose steam

Ayanti Bera

Bengaluru: AI-powered match-making startups are drawing fresh investor interest as traditional dating apps struggle to keep users engaged. Marriage-focused platform Knot.dating is in the market to raise \$5-8 million, while Bengaluru-based Wavelength recently raised \$500,000 in pre-seed funding from Antler.

Rather than offering users more profiles to swipe through, these startups are using AI to narrow choices and improve the chances of a successful match.

"Existing dating apps don't work because people in this process don't know what they want or how to evaluate and judge the other person," Vinit Sarode, cofounder of Wavelength, told ET.

Personalised matchmaking can lead to better outcomes, he said. Wavelength's AI agent, Wave, for example, conducts a 15-minute conversation with users to understand their dating history, priorities, aspirations and personality before creating their profile. Instead of presenting multiple potential matches, it introduces one person at a time and explains why they could be a fit.

Knot.dating is pursuing a similar AI-led model, but with a sharper focus on marriage. "Once you match, there is a 15-minute intro call, and then we set you up for a meeting, skipping the chat part where a majority of conversations die," said Jasveer Singh, cofounder and CEO of Knot.dating.

Women account for 60-65% of Knot.dating's users and for about 35% in the case of Wavelength that has recorded 14,000 sign-ups since launching its beta in April.

The opportunity comes as established dating platforms face pressure on user growth. Bumble's paying user base, for example, fell 12% year-on-year to 3.7 million in 2025, and another 16% in the quarter ended June.

But carmakers caution that E20 alone cannot explain the

GLOBAL SUBSCRIBERS (M)

Bumble Match Group

2024 2025 2026*

4.1 14.6 3.7 14.2 3.2 13.3

Source: Company data

INDIA CELEBRATES 80TH INDEPENDENCE DAY

Modi calls for stepping up mfg, farm, tech and innovation play, strengthening defence, infra, blue & green economy; announces AI training, free coaching for youth preparing for exams

PM Lists Saptadhara Plan for Viksit Bharat

Our Political Bureau NEW DELHI

In his address to the nation on the 80th Independence Day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi outlined a seven-pronged framework — Saptadhara — to help India become a developed country, built around seven focus areas from manufacturing to soft power, and sought the engagement of youth to realise the vision.

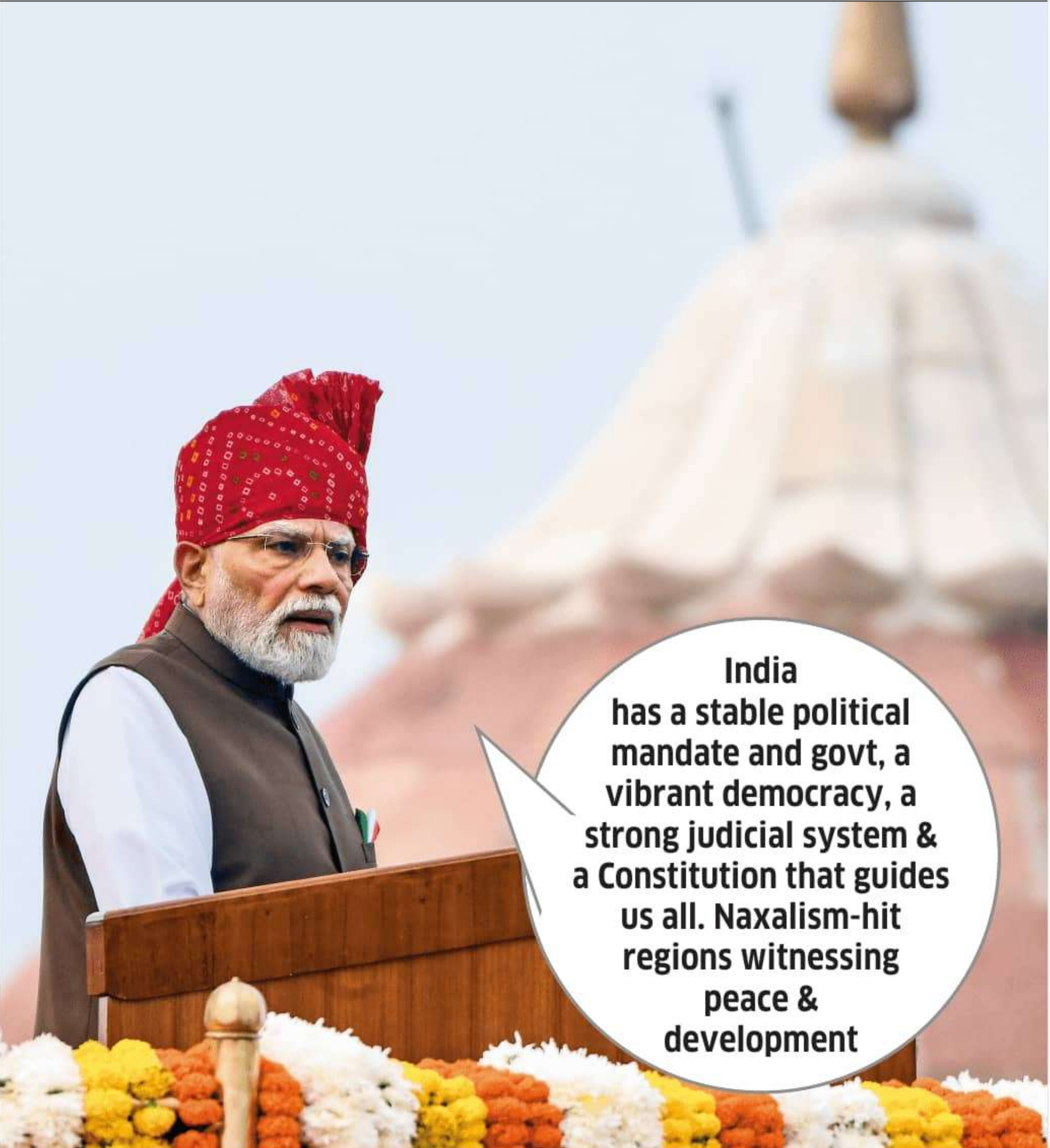
In his 13th consecutive address from the ramparts of Red Fort, Modi combined a long-term economic and development vision with political and social messaging, and appealed to the opposition to cooperate in implementing 33% reservation for women.

The Saptadhara or Sapt Shakti include manufacturing power; agriculture and food processing; technology and innovation; Gati Shakti; defence Shakti; green and blue economy; and India's soft power, the prime minister said.

He said every Indian is embracing the spirit of 'Make in India' and 'Vocal for Local' initiatives. To boost manufacturing, India should "build complete domestic end-to-end value chains, from design to components, focusing on zero-defect quality, cost, and global scale," he added.

In agriculture and food processing, he called for integrated farm-to-export supply chains for millets, spices and fruits, and a transition to chemical-free farming. On technology, the prime minister said, "The country needs to evolve from a tech market into a global innovation hub leading in AI, quantum, space, robotics, DPI, and Made-in-India 6G."

Through Gati Shakti, a concept he had envisaged earlier, the country is establishing high-speed, seamless multimodal logistics connecting cities, highways, rail, airports and modern industrial seaports. Modi also emphasised that India needs to become Atmanirbhar in defence. "Through Defence Shakti, the country should achieve complete strategic self-reliance by pioneering and exporting next-generation defence technologies like



PM Narendra Modi addresses the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort in New Delhi on Independence Day

drones, counter-drone systems and hypersonic," he said.

Modi called for a stronger push towards green and blue economy through scale across green hydrogen, renewables and energy storage alongside full utilisation of ocean, coastal and marine potential.

He stressed the need to harness India's soft power by globalising Indian culture, yoga and Ayurveda, promoting tourism, and establishing global leadership in gaming, VFX, animation, and creative economy. He also urged the industry not to compromise on quality "as it builds trust in Indian products."

For the first time, the full version of Vande Mataram was played at flag hoisting, followed by unfurling of the national tricolour and the national anthem. "India has a stable political mandate, a stable government, a vibrant democracy, a strong judicial system and a

India has a stable political mandate and govt, a vibrant democracy, a strong judicial system & a Constitution that guides us all. Naxalism-hit regions witnessing peace & development

FOCUS ON SELF-RELIANCE

India may See 5-8 More Chip Plants Going On Stream within 8 Years: PM

Need to build entire semicon supply chain as nations weaponising critical tech, says Modi

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Five to eight additional semiconductor facilities are expected to begin operations in India over the next seven to eight years, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Friday, highlighting the country's push to become self-reliant in chip manufacturing.

"The world has reached a point

where the entire system could come to a standstill without chips. That is why, Bharat has begun establishing its own semiconductor manufacturing capacity in the direction of becoming self-reliant," Modi said during his address to the nation on the 80th Independence Day.

Three semiconductor assem-

RIDING THE WAVE

COMMERCIAL PRODUCTION, EXPORTS STARTED FROM 3 CHIP PLANTS IN 2026

Micron Tech, CG Semi, Kaynes Semicon

9 PLANTS APPROVED UNDER ISM 1.0

Chip fabrication unit Tata Electronics

Compound fabrication Units

OSATs India Chip, 3D Glass Solutions, Tata Electronics, CDIL, ASIP, Suchi Semicon

SicSem, Crystal Matrix

₹1.27 Lcr Approved under ISM 2.0 in July

bly, testing, marking and packaging (ATMP) units of Micron Technology, Kaynes Semicon and CG Semi have begun commercial production this year. Located in Sanand, these plants have also started exports, he said.

These, along with nine other semiconductor facilities, including a fabrication unit being built by Tata Electronic, have been approved under the ₹76,000-crore first phase of the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) so far.

The Centre approved the ₹1.27 lakh-crore second phase of ISM last month.

Administrative notification for the same is expected soon, officials said.

'A Trusted Hub' >> 7

AS CHANDRA FORGOES ANOTHER TERM

Twist in Tata Tale Tests India Inc's Succession Script

Finding right leader in case of an abrupt exit becomes more challenging for cos

Sreeradha Basu & Lijee Philip

Bengaluru | Mumbai: N Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek another term as chairman of Tata Sons has revived a question that boards often prefer not to confront: how prepared are they for a change at the top?

The real test of succession planning, however, is not whether a board has a successor in mind, but whether an organisation can absorb an unexpected departure without missing a beat.

The paradox is that the more successful a leader is, the harder succession can become. Boards may focus on extending the tenure of a proven leader rather than building a pipeline of people who can eventually take over. "The 'very big shoes to fill' factor comes into play in these situations," said Anandorup Ghose, partner at Deloitte India.

The trustees of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust have initiated the process of appointing a selection committee to find Chandra's successor, putting the broader question of leadership succession in the spotlight.

"Most companies try and put succession in place. Companies may decide but don't announce it," said a board member of a Mumbai-based conglomerate.

But many are less prepared for what he calls the "hit-by-a-bus" scenario, like when a CMD expected to stay for several ye-

Planning for Change

Succession planning isn't just about having a successor in mind

It also focuses on being ready in case of a sudden exit

TICKING THE RIGHT BOXES

- Ready bench
- Smooth handover
- Business continuity

MAJOR CHALLENGES

More successful a leader is, harder succession can become

Many companies less prepared for 'hit-by-a-bus' scenario

ars suddenly leaves.

For listed companies, succession planning is ultimately a board responsibility, with the nomination and remuneration committee playing a key role. "When succession planning is not in place, boards have to be blamed," the person added.

"There is a regulatory mandate to disclose whether there is a succession plan, but whether it's implemented in full spirit, or whether it is just for the purpose of checking a tick box varies across companies," said Shriram Subramanian, MD at corporate governance advisory firm InGovern.

Taking Calculated Risks >> 7

DEMAND-SUPPLY GAP GROWING FOR EMERGING TECH ROLES

Investors Help Cos Hire AI Talent

Investors, including venture capital firms, are supporting Indian companies and startups that are struggling to find talent, as demand for artificial intelligence roles such as AI security, AI evaluation and agentic AI grows, reports Prachi Verma. >> 3

POTENTIAL INFLECTION POINT FOR AUTO INC

Choices Aplenty for Car Buyers, Petrol Moves to Slow Lane

Fewer on Road

■ Jul '25 ■ Jun '26 ■ Jul '26

PETROL CAR RETAIL SALES (in units)

Maharashtra	Uttar Pradesh	Haryana	Delhi	Rajasthan
14,615	13,936	9,028	7,445	6,821
14,460	14,460	7,941	6,944	6,044
13,800	13,058	7,929	6,593	5,959

Source: Vahan



CNG, hybrids, EVs chip away at petrol's share; E20 worries add to broader shift

Lijee Philip

Mumbai: Petrol is losing its grip on India's car market, with sales coming under pressure in some of the country's biggest automobile markets as buyers increasingly look beyond conventional fuel.

Across Maharashtra, Haryana, Delhi, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, petrol cars are losing ground even as CNG, hybrids and electric vehicles gain momentum, while diesel is seeing renewed interest in some markets. Adding to the shift is growing consumer anxiety over E20 petrol. Industry executives said concerns about mileage, compatibility and long-term ownership are increasingly featuring in purchase decisions.

But carmakers caution that E20 alone cannot explain the

pressure on petrol. The bigger shift, they said, is that consumers now have more alternatives, with the economics and availability of these powertrains making them increasingly credible choices.

The shift is therefore not simply from petrol to electric vehicles. CNG is attracting buyers seeking lower running costs, while hybrids offer a middle ground for those looking for better fuel efficiency without depending on charging infrastructure. EVs are gaining traction as charging networks expand, while diesel continues to find buyers in markets and segments where range, highway driving and fuel efficiency remain important.

For the auto industry, this marks a fundamental change in how consumers choose cars.

Towards Alternate-fuel Vehicles >> 7

INDEPENDENCE DAY FUNCTION AT BAKSHI STADIUM IN SRINAGAR

A Look Across LoC Vindicates Sheikh Abdullah's India Choice: Omar

J&K CM says decisions taken in 2019 abrogating Article 370 and 35A prevented people across the LoC from seeking merger with the Valley

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Jammu and Kashmir chief minister Omar Abdullah said the situation across the Line of Control vindicated his grandfather Sheikh Muhammad Abdullah's decision to fight the tribal raiders who invaded the region in 1947 and join the Indian Union.

Addressing the Independence Day function at Bakshi Stadium in Srinagar, Abdullah said that had the decisions taken in 2019 not been implemented—when Article 370 and 35A were abrogated and the erstwhile state was downgraded into the two Union Territories of

J&K and Ladakh—people in Muzaffarabad would today be protesting to demand their merger with this side of the region.

Pakistan-occupied Kashmir has witnessed violent protests against the government in recent weeks, which also continued during the recently concluded assembly elections there.

Abdullah said his government remained committed to fighting for the restoration of special status, constitutional guarantees and statehood for the region.

"Today witnessing the situation across LoC, the decision of my grandfather and his associates to fight raiders, tribals and invaders



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah in Srinagar on Saturday—IANs

in 1947 was right. Today when we see the situation across the LoC, we are sad. I feel that if our situation was not changed in 2019, the people from the other side of LoC would be protesting to rejoin us again," said Abdullah.

He said people across the LoC were no strangers and belonged to them. "That part of J&K is ours. We don't consider them as strangers. Even today we have seats in our assembly for them and hope that one day they will fill these seats," said Abdullah.

Reciting lines from poet Iqbal's Sare Jahan Se Acha, Abdullah said democracy and federalism were the two greatest strengths of India.

"We have to save and strengthen

That part of J&K is ours. We don't consider them as strangers. Even today we have seats in our assembly for them and hope that one day they will fill these seats

OMAR ABDULLAH

Chief Minister, Jammu & Kashmir

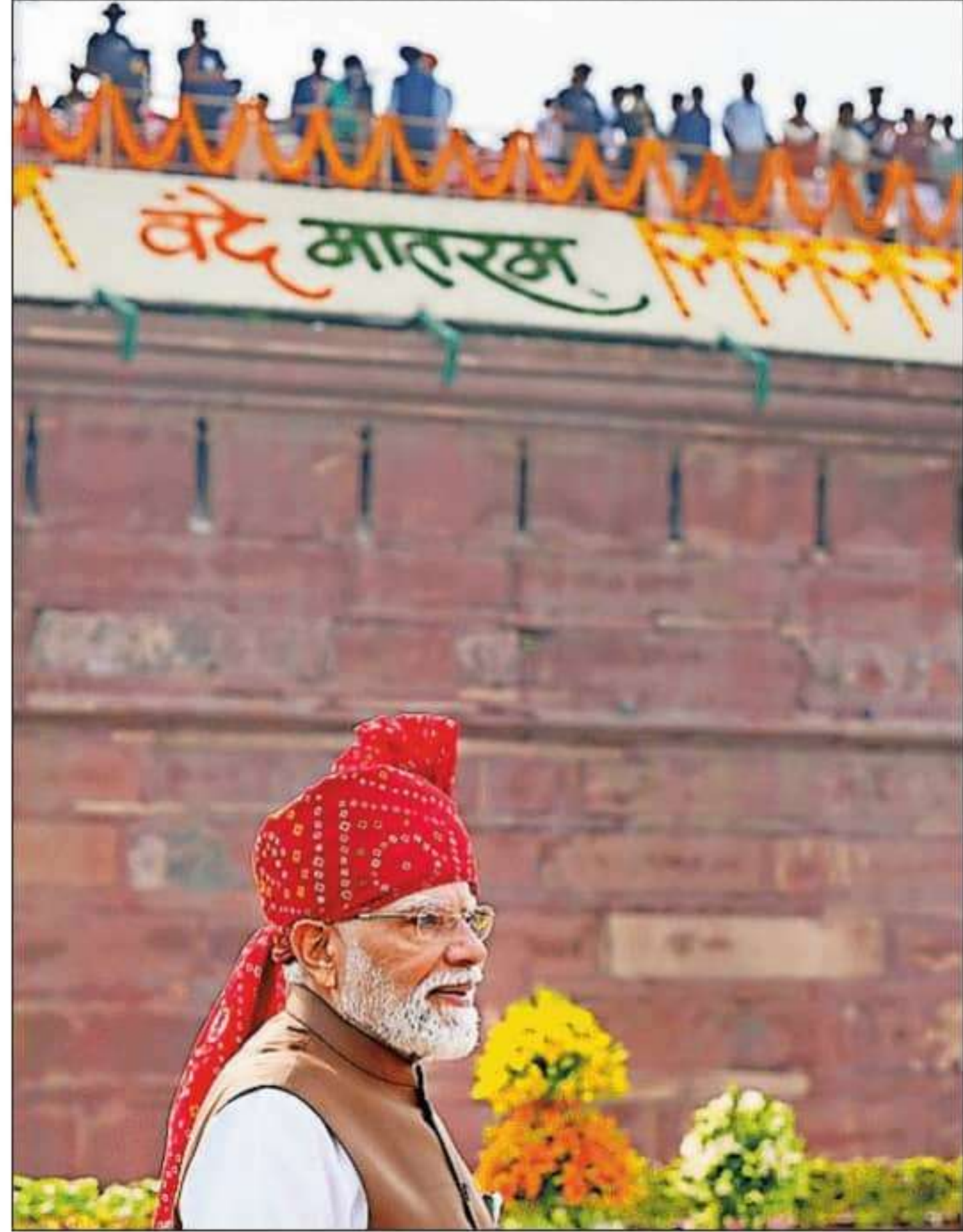
both democracy and federalism. Federalism should be strengthened. It should start from J&K by restoration of everything that was snatched from us in 2019. Every state has to be strengthened and it will give a fresh lease of life to federalism," said Abdullah.

He said interventions and interference by central agencies harmed and weakened federalism.

"Erosion of powers of states, harms federalism. People often come out on the streets because of this and we saw the same at Jantar Mantar," said Abdullah.

The J&K chief minister said examinations and admissions to state institutions should be handled by the states, while the central government could handle admissions and recruitment to national institutions such as the IITs.

"...we hope that the examination and recruitment process in J&K is transparent and only those get the chance who deserve it," said Abdullah.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Red Fort



President Droupadi Murmu during the 'At Home' at the Rashtrapati Bhavan Cultural Centre



Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar



Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren



Student leader Devendra Nath Mahto allegedly gets stopped by police from participating in the 'Tiranga Yatra' in Ranchi



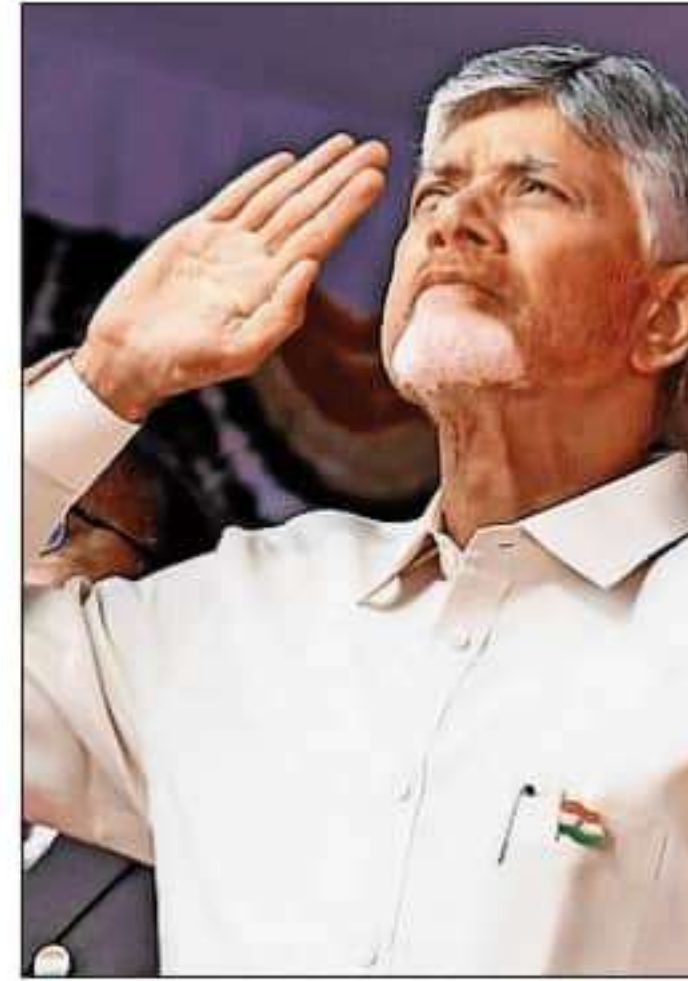
Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath



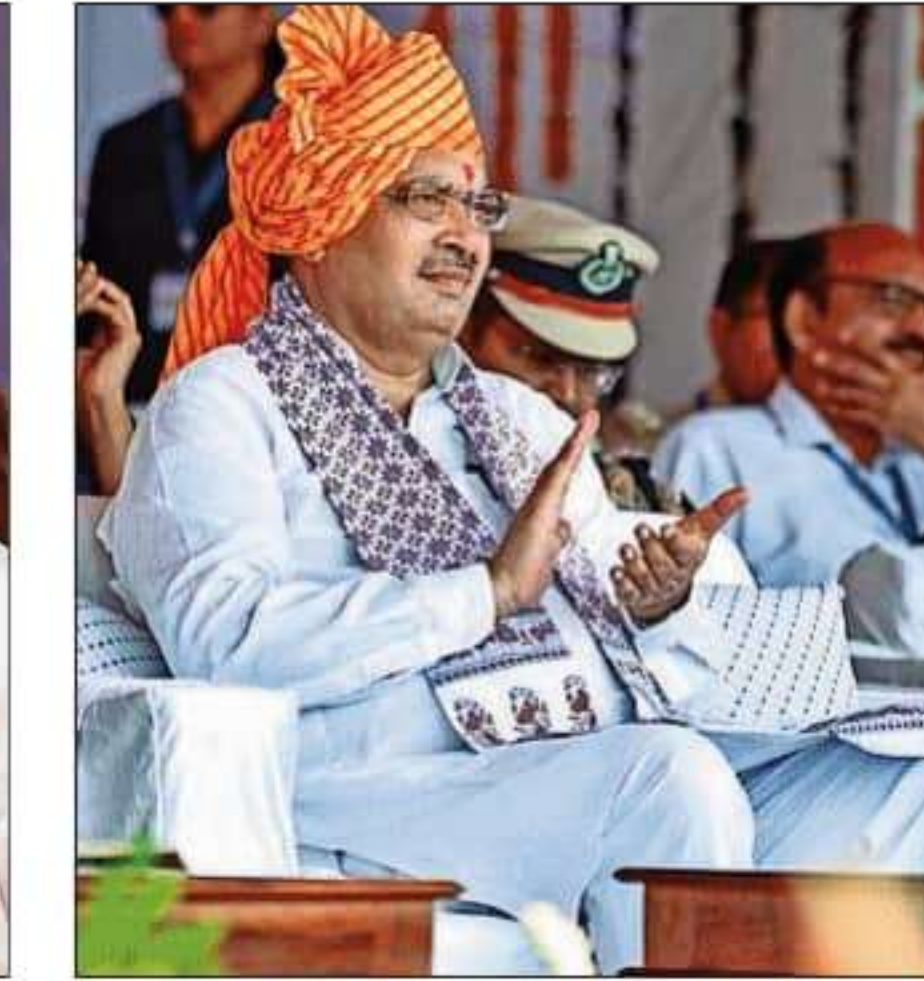
Lal Chowk in Srinagar



Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay



AP CM Chandrababu Naidu



Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma

BACKING STUDENTS

Questions of Public Interest Must Be Raised Forcefully, Says RSS Chief



Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat has twice in recent days said that "opposing views and raising questions in public interest are necessary" in a democracy, referring to the student protests.

Speaking at an Independence Day event in Nagpur on Saturday, Bhagwat said the demographic dividend can help the country become a "Vishwaguru" if it is nurtured well.

"There will be different views, and there will be different ways of expressing those views; that is democracy. Here there is dialogue, debate and a manner of presenting one's arguments. There will be different viewpoints, there will be opposition, too," Bhagwat said.

"When questions are raised in the public interest, they must be raised forcefully. We must put our strength behind them."

The RSS chief said that while there would be "protests and movements" in a democracy, one must be aware of duties too: Bhagwat

Addressing the youth, Bhagwat said, "It is being said that youth are our demographic dividend and if utilised well, they could well help the country become a 'Vishwaguru'."

FULL NATIONAL SONG IN KARNATAKA, TELANGANA AND HIMACHAL PRADESH

Sonia's Gestures During Full 'Vande Mataram' at I-Day Event Spark Row

BJP accuses Sonia of obstructing rendition; Cong says Gandhi was seeking chair for Kharge

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Congress headquarters witnessed dramatic scenes during the party's official Independence Day function on Saturday, when party workers and singers rendered the full version of the national song Vande Mataram, prompting Sonia Gandhi to gesture disapprovingly towards party president Mallikarjun Kharge, the singers and Seva Dal functionaries.

Gandhi also called a Seva Dal functionary and spoke animatedly to him while Vande Mataram was still being sung. The episode went viral on television channels and social media, prompting the BJP to accuse Gandhi of trying to obstruct the rendition of the national song. The Cong-

ress sought to contain the fallout, saying the full Vande Mataram was sung at the function and that Gandhi's gestures were aimed at getting a chair for Kharge, who had been standing for a long time.

"There were no arguments or attempts to obstruct it. The Congress president was standing for a long time and Sonia ji was asking for a chair for him," Congress spokesperson Jai Ram Ramesh said.

The episode also left some Congress functionaries privately wondering whether the full rendition of the national song at the party event was contrary to the leadership's plan.

KERALA SKIPS IT

Meanwhile, the full Vande Mataram was sung at official Independence Day functions in Congress-ruled Karnataka, Telangana and Himachal Pradesh. It was, however, skipped at the official Independence Day event of the Congress-led UDF government in Kerala, prompting the BJP to allege that pressure from the Indian Union Muslim League had forced the decision.



KHARGE, RAHUL SKIP RED FORT I-DAY EVENT

Youth's Dreams Being Trampled: Kharge

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge attacked the Modi government in his Independence Day message, alleging that the dreams of the country's youth were being trampled upon and that a hate campaign had been launched against those staging protests.

Kharge and Rahul Gandhi, the leaders of the opposition in the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha, respectively, also stayed away from the Independence Day function at the Red Fort, as they did last year. Congress sources claimed the two were not provided proper protocol and seating arrangements.

"What is happening to our youth?"

Today, the dreams of the youth are being trampled (upon). The country's youth are agitating, and we, along with the leader of the opposition, are supporting them. The Constitution grants everyone the right to protest for their cause; they are not anti-nationals. But, hate campaigns are launched against those who protest," Kharge said while addressing the Congress Independence Day function.

He also accused the BJP-RSS of indulging in divisive politics aimed at keeping society divided.

Kharge questioned the silence of the prime minister and the home minister over police action against agitating students.

He also raised the issue of alleged donation theft at the Ram temple to target the prime minister.



CONGRESS COMMITTEE

AS MODI GOVT LOOKS TO RESET TIES

Bangladesh PM Likely to Visit India Next Week

Dhaka works on dates for two-day trip; energy, power & water-sharing to figure in talks

Dipanjana Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman is weighing a two-day visit to India next week after New Delhi invited him for bilateral talks, in a possible effort to arrest a drift in ties between the neighbours.

Two sets of dates are being considered—August 20-21 or August 21-22. If the visit goes ahead, the Indian go-

vernment could offer Bangladesh projects aimed at supporting its economy, people familiar with the matter said.

ET had reported earlier this week that Rahman was considering a standalone visit to India ahead of the Brics Summit. Bangladesh has been invited to the summit as the current Bimstec chair. India has also invited Asean, the Gulf Cooperation Council, African Union and Grulac as outreach partners for the summit.

"Both sides have been interested in a bilateral visit, but the schedule was an issue. After weighing various schedules, the top officials of both co-

untries have come close to a schedule between August 20 and 25," Bangladesh's English-language daily The Daily Star reported on Saturday.

The visit would be Rahman's first to India since he assumed office in February. The Narendra Modi government could consider support for Bangladesh's energy and power sector during his visit.

Bangladesh needs energy supplies amid the Iran war, which has affected global energy supplies through the Strait of Hormuz.

Water sharing is another major issue. The Ganges Water Treaty ex-

pires in December, while the Teesta water-sharing agreement remains unresolved despite efforts dating back to 2011.

Rahman's first foreign visit as prime minister was to Malaysia, followed by China, despite India's invitation for a bilateral visit soon after he assumed office.

People familiar with the matter said hardliners in the current government in Dhaka and the pro-Pakistan Jama'at-e-Islami have been trying to influence Rahman's outreach to India. New Delhi, however, is keen to make another effort to engage the Bangladesh prime minister.

A delay in Rahman's India visit could leave bilateral ties at a standstill and risk further deterioration, the people said.

Statement
Kumar Anshuman

Bankipur Loss Prompts BJP to Woo Upper Castes

A loss in the Bankipur assembly constituency has changed the BJP's approach to electoral politics in Bihar. The election came in the aftermath of the UGC issue, paper leak, Bharat Tiwari encounter and Gen Z protest. The BJP in the state feels its core upper-caste voter is unhappy with the party and sided with Jan Suraj leader Prashant Kishore. The party is now back to wooing its core upper-caste voter.

Last week, the Savarna Ayog in Bihar appointed district nodal officers to help people register their grievances at the district level rather than travelling to Patna. The government was facing questions over the encounter of Bharat Tiwari in central Bihar by the police. On Thursday, CM Samrat Choudhary announced a government job for one of Tiwari's family members and promised financial assistance.

"Based on the interim report of the judicial inquiry, the Bihar government will provide financial assistance to the family of the late Bharat Tiwari and offer a government job to one family member," Choudhary posted on X.



VARANI SAHU

The government is also mulling the recommendations of the Savarna Ayog, which include extending free coaching facilities for competitive examinations to EWS category students and enrolling EWS and upper-caste students in residential schools to be run by the government.

The focus is more on the upcoming generation. In his Independence Day speech, Choudhary promised to start a special portal where students can register their complaints regarding school infrastructure, examinations and other requirements. The government will address the complaints within a month. The portal will start working from Monday.

Akhilesh Warns Leaders Against Loose Talk That Could Help BJP

With assembly elections in sight, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav doesn't want to take any chance.

While speaking to party leaders on Saturday, Yadav said leaders should be careful in their speech.

"Elections are near. We just have to finalise tickets. No leader should make any statement which BJP can take advantage of. We will issue detailed instructions on what to speak and what not," Yadav said.

The comment is significant as Yadav is trying to forge a strong caste coalition in his favour.

Last week, he addressed a meet-

ing of influential people from the Brahmin community, where he said that "PD" in his PDA formula, among other things, stands for Pandit.

In May this year, a statement by SP spokesperson Rajkumar Bhati went viral on social media, in which he made some controversial remarks about Brahmins. Bhati later apologised for his comments.

Yadav understands the importance of caste groups. Some people in Uttarakhnad purified the stage used by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge. Kharge raised the issue as humiliation because he comes from the SC community. Yadav was quick to react, saying that the PDA society is no longer in the mood to tolerate its humiliation.

SP leaders claim that the consolidation of PDA (Pichda, Dalit and Alpankhyak) helped the SP win the maximum number of seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. Now the party wants to add new caste groups to make a formidable combination ahead of the assembly polls.



Soren Urges President, PM to Reconsider Mines Bill

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren has raised serious objections to The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, passed by Parliament during the Monsoon Session. His party, JMM, opposed the Bill in both Houses along with several other Opposition parties. Now that the Bill has been passed, Soren has written to President Droupadi Murmu and PM Modi, urging them to reconsider certain amendments and provisions. He has also written to Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, seeking his support in his fight to preserve the state's right to tax mines and minerals.

In his letter, Soren mentioned that a nine-judge Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court upheld the legislative competence of states to tax mineral-bearing lands in their respective states. Under the new Bill, states can still levy cess or tax on minerals, but this will now be subject to conditions mentioned by the central government.



Soren said the Bill will have a significant financial impact on Jharkhand, as mining revenue accounts for 84.9% of the state's own non-tax revenue. The government was expecting to raise around ₹11,000 crore annually through cess on mine-bearing land.

Soren has warned that if the central government does not reconsider the Bill, there will be widespread agitation across every block and district in Jharkhand, with demands to restore the state's rights over its mines and mineral resources.

BECOMES NO. 1 AI MODEL

Alibaba's Qwen Beats Google, Meta With 3B AI Downloads

Bloomberg

Alibaba Group Holding's open-weight models have accumulated more than 3 billion global downloads in the past six months, eclipsing Meta Platforms Inc., Alphabet Inc. and domestic peers to become the world's No. 1 artificial-intelligence model.

Qwen, Alibaba's family of AI models, has open-sourced more than 460 models and its ecosystem has spawned 300,000-plus derivatives, the Chinese technology company said in an emailed statement.

Google, part of Alphabet, had 418 million downloads while Meta stood at 227 million in 2026, according to popular open-source AI hub Hugging Face Inc., which published a state of open models report on



August 14. Open models can be downloaded, customized and used as building blocks for new AI products, making adoption a gauge of which technologies developers are choosing to build on. That has made download and derivative-model figures one measure of influence in the US-China AI race, as Chinese developers including Alibaba push capable models that are relatively cheap and easy to adapt. Qwen's rise suggests that strategy is gaining traction beyond China.

Qwen along with Moonshot AI Inc, DeepSeek and Chinese AI model builders are replicating frontier performance, seeking to bridge the gap with closed models in US, such as OpenAI Inc. and Anthropic PBC. Export controls on chips and AI systems, such as the brief ban on overseas access to Anthropic's Fable 5 model this summer, don't appear to be putting the brakes on Chinese competitors.

MOST POSITIONS WERE NON-EXISTENT A FEW YEARS AGO

As Country's AI Talent Gap Grows, Investors Step in to Help Cos Hire

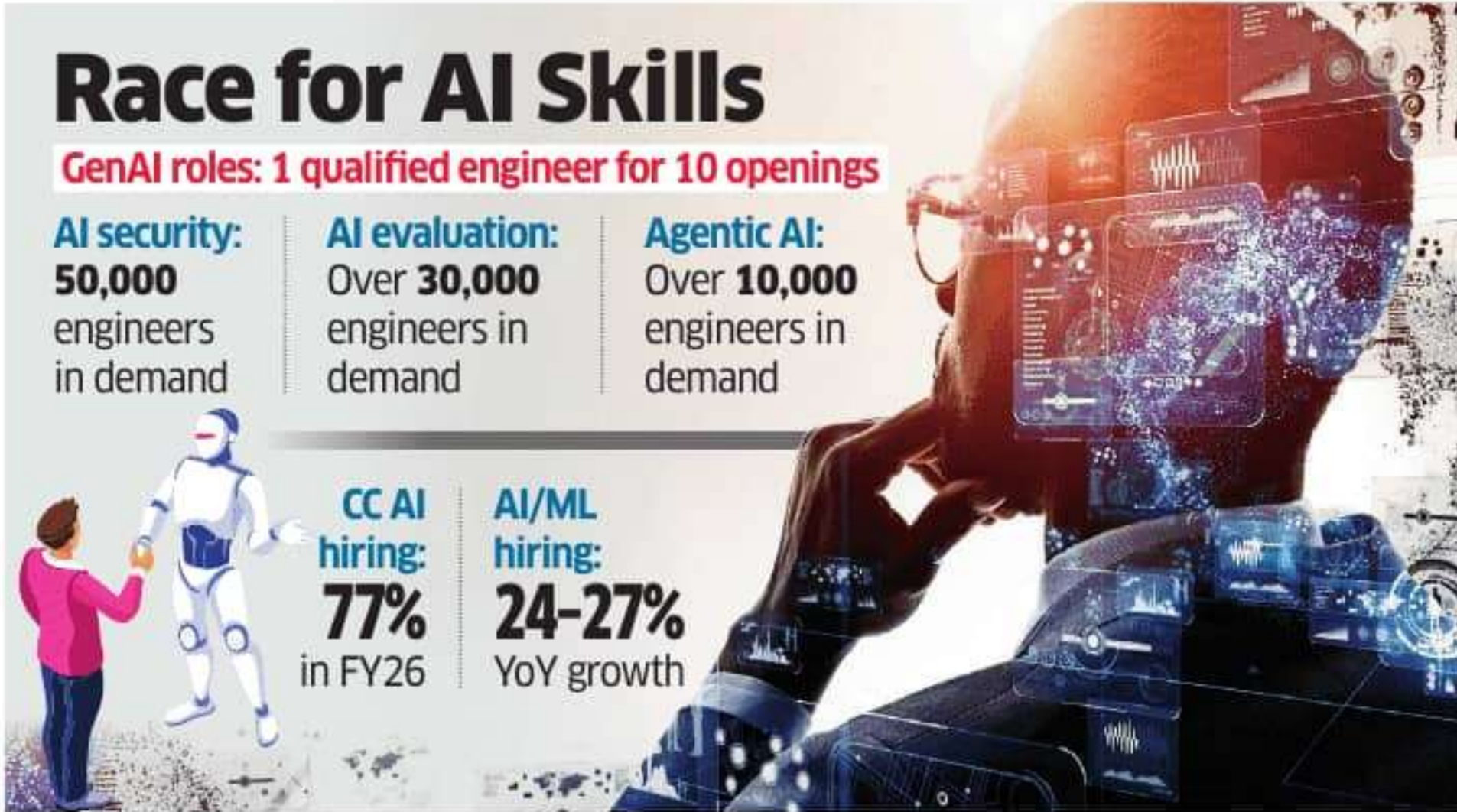
Demand-supply gap is only getting wider for emerging tech roles, according to experts

Prachi Verma

New Delhi: With technology evolving rapidly, companies and startups in India are struggling to find talent for emerging artificial intelligence (AI) roles, prompting investors, including venture capital firms, to support enterprises with finding tech talent.

Experts said the demand-supply gap is only getting wider for emerging tech talent. Data shared with The Economic Times by CIEL HR Services shows demand for about 50,000 AI security engineers, more than 30,000 AI evaluation engineers and over 10,000 agentic AI engineers.

Most of these positions were vir-



tually non-existent a few years ago. Separately, TeamLease data, based on over 30,000 salary observations across technology, global capability centres (GCCs) and non-tech sectors, points to an AI talent gap of more than 53%. "For every 10 open GenAI roles, only one qualified engineer is available," according to TeamLease.

"These are not cyclical numbers. They describe a workforce that

has not caught up with the work," said Neeti Sharma, chief executive officer, TeamLease Digital.

The data also shows the share of mid-to-senior AI hiring at GCCs increased to 77% in FY26 from 60% in 2023, while hiring in traditional IT roles turned negative.

According to Sharma, AI and machine learning remains the only category posting double-digit growth, at 24-27% year-on-year,

while most other white-collar segments are growing in single digits, stagnating or shrinking.

CIEL chief executive Aditya Mishra said companies are increasingly seeking talent for specialised AI functions. "These roles almost did not exist a few years ago," he said.

The shortage is also leading to investors supporting startups to find tech talent.

"At IvyCap, we believe that while technology may be the foundation of a DeepTech or AI startup, people ultimately determine its success," said Vikram Gupta, founder and managing partner, IvyCap Ventures.

According to Gupta, founders often begin with strong technical expertise, but scaling requires leadership talent across product development, engineering, business development, operations and international expansion.

"As long-term investors, we work closely with portfolio companies beyond providing capital," he said.

Govt Weighs PNG Drive 3.0 to Speed up Adoption; Launch Likely in Sept

Kalpna Pathak

Mumbai: The government is planning PNG Drive 3.0 to speed up the process of homes and industries switching to piped natural gas (PNG), two officials aware of the development said.

The drive could be launched as early as September, they told ET.

The government launched its second PNG adoption drive after India's liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supply chain came under pressure amid global uncertainties linked to the war in Iran, which disrupted shipping routes and affected LPG availability in the country.

It set a target of up to 100,000 new PNG connections a day to further reduce its LPG import and subsidy burden. City gas distribution (CGD) companies responded by ac-



celerating the rollout of PNG connections to households. The push saw the number of PNG connections added daily jump to around 10,000, up from 4,000-5,000 a month before the start of the war. However, the officials cited earlier said the ministry is dissatisfied with the progress.

"After seeing some traction that PNG received in the past two rounds of promoting the segment,

the ministry of petroleum and natural gas (MoPNG) is considering launching another round to promote PNG adoption," said one of the officials.

The petroleum ministry did not immediately respond to an emailed query on the matter.

At present, over 20 million homes in India have PNG connections. The others mostly rely on LPG for their cooking needs.

The ministry is keen to push PNG adoption in cities where a CGD network is already available but still has high usage of LPG.

The government is also encouraging commercial consumers such as restaurants, hotels and industrial units to switch to PNG from LPG, the officials said.

"Adding 100,000 connections daily is impossible. Especially given the shortage of gas plumbers and technicians," said one of the officials quoted above. "Companies are still trying their best to meet the target as much as possible." Mahanagar Gas Ltd (MGL), one of the largest CGD companies in India, said it added 95,000 household connections in the last quarter; its highest-ever quarterly addition.

"We can go from 1,000 connections a day to more than that as well—2,000, 3,000 also," MGL told analysts recently.

Manipur Rivals Unite Against Border Land Swap With Myanmar

Shantanu Nandan Sharma

New Delhi: More than three years after ethnic clashes between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities plunged Manipur into a bitter conflict, an unlikely point of convergence has emerged: both sides are now opposed to any possible swapping of land with Myanmar.

The issue concerns a reported proposal to exchange around 3.5 sq km of territory in Manipur's Chandel district along the India-Myanmar border. While the Manipur Valley's civil society body, the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), last month came out strongly against any move to cede even a small portion of Manipur's territory to Myanmar, Kuki villagers in the border villages of Khengiang and Molcham in Chandel district took their opposition to the streets on August 11, protesting against any possible realignment of the existing boundary.

"Kuki Inpi Chandel expresses deep concern and strong opposition to any such proposal of 'territorial exchange' or land swap in the area," said a statement shared with ET and signed by the Kuki civil society body's general secretary Shokhoin Mate. The statement referred specifically to reports of negotiations between India and Myanmar concerning the stretch between boundary pillars 65 and 68 in Chandel district.

At a press conference in New Delhi earlier this month, a spokesman for the ministry of external affairs (MEA) acknowledged that there are certain stretches of the India-Myanmar border "which

A Myanmar Land Swap?

Reported: About 3.5 sq km of territory

Government position: Some stretches of the India-Myanmar border are "yet to be settled", with discussions ongoing

What remains unclear: Whether the reported proposal is a territorial exchange or part of the process of precisely identifying and demarcating the existing international boundary

The challenge: Large parts of Myanmar's Sagaing Region across the border are controlled by rebel groups



are yet to be settled", also adding that discussions on those sectors are ongoing.

The issue gained attention last month after The Diplomat, citing a government document, reported that about "1.4 square miles" of territory had been "proposed to be exchanged with Myanmar following a proposal from the foreign secretary".

"The matter, it seems, is under discussion; nothing is finalised as yet. So, we must not jump the gun," Lt Gen L Nishikanta Singh (retired) said.

CBDT Opens One-Time Window For Taxpayers to Declare Foreign Assets

Taxpayers can declare foreign assets up to ₹5 crore by paying a ₹1 lakh fee

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The government has opened a one-time window for taxpayers to declare foreign income and assets up to ₹5 crore which they failed to disclose in previous tax filings.

The move, announced in Union Budget 2026-27, does not offer an amnesty for black money or undisclosed foreign wealth. Instead, it creates a limited window for taxpayers to resolve specified foreign-asset reporting lapses, including cases where assets were acquired from income earned while the taxpayer was a non-resident or where the underlying income was already offered to tax in India but the foreign asset was omitted from the relevant disclosure schedule.

Under the new compliance window opening on Sunday, taxpayers with specified foreign assets worth up to ₹5 crore can now come clean on past disclosure lapses by paying a ₹1-lakh fee, while those with undisclosed foreign assets and income of up to ₹1 crore can regularise them by paying tax and penalty amounting to 60% of the declared value.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) on Friday notified the Foreign



Assets of Small Taxpayers—Disclosure Scheme, 2026 (FAST-DS).

The board said declarations can be filed until December 31, 2026 and set March 31, 2026 as the date for valuation.

The scheme covers a wide range of overseas assets, including foreign bank accounts, immovable property, bullion, jewellery and precious stones, paintings, sculptures, archaeological collections and other artistic works, foreign mutual funds, quoted and unquoted shares and securities, and interests in foreign partnership firms, associations of persons and limited liability partnerships (LLPs). The ₹5 crore route is specifically

aimed at assets that fall within the category where the assets were acquired when the taxpayer was non-resident or where proper declaration was not made. The threshold applies to their aggregate value.

A taxpayer holding foreign mutual funds worth Rs 2.5 crore and overseas securities worth Rs 4 crore, for instance, would have Rs 6.5 crore of eligible assets and would fall outside the scheme.

The other route is for an undisclosed foreign asset or undisclosed foreign income, or both, aggregating up to Rs 1 crore. Here, the taxpayer has to pay 30% tax and an equal amount as penalty, taking the effective payment to 60%.

If a taxpayer is holding an undisclosed foreign bank account valued at Rs 60 lakh and having undisclosed foreign income of Rs 20 lakh, the tax is Rs 24 lakh and an equal amount is payable as penalty, resulting in a total liability of Rs 48 lakh, the frequently asked questions (FAQs) by the department explain.

The rules provide detailed valuation mechanisms for different classes of assets. Property, jewellery and artwork are generally valued at open market price on March 31 or acquisition cost, whichever is higher.

THE TRICOLOUR MAKES A SYMBOLIC JOURNEY FROM FIJI TO SAN FRANCISCO

India Marks I-Day with 'Suryapath Tiranga' Campaign Across the Globe

PTI

London: The Indian tricolour is making a symbolic journey across the globe from east to west on the country's 80th Independence Day, being hoisted successively at Indian missions worldwide from Fiji to San Francisco.

The initiative has been named Suryapath Tiranga, which is part of the broader Har Ghar Tiranga campaign, a nationwide and global programme encouraging Indians and members of the diaspora to display the national flag as they celebrate Independence Day. The initiative began in the small Pacific island nation of Fiji at 1:30 am IST (8 am local time), where High Commissioner Suneet Mehta hoisted the Tricolour at India



A performance during the 80th Independence Day celebrations featuring the 'Suryapath Tiranga' global relay in London

House in Suva. The flag then moved westward across Indian missions, with celebrations taking place in New Zealand, Australia, Japan, South Korea, China, Indonesia, Vietnam, Singapore, Malaysia, Thailand, Myanmar, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lan-

ka, Maldives, Uzbekistan, Oman, the UAE, Qatar, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia.

The flag-hoisting subsequently moved across Asia, Africa and Europe, covering Indian missions in Ethiopia, Russia, Kenya, Israel, Egypt, South Africa, Latvia, Germa-

ny, Italy, Belgium, the Netherlands, France, the UK, Spain, Morocco and Iceland.

Moving to the Americas, the Indian flag will then be hoisted at Indian missions in Brazil, Suriname, Guyana, Argentina, Trinidad & Tobago, Dominican Republic, Colombia, Canada (Ottawa and Toronto), Jamaica, the US (New York and Washington), Peru and Mexico.

The final flag of the day will be hoisted by the Indian consulate in San Francisco, where the relay is scheduled to conclude around 8:30 pm IST. In Wellington, over 500 members of the Indian diaspora and local friends joined the Independence Day celebrations, where High Commissioner Muanpui Saiawi hoisted the tricolour and read the President's address.

TOI

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Nupur Amarnath

It was a regular Tuesday evening, 7:10 pm. I was done for the day. But going home was not an option. Not yet. After all, Bengaluru traffic would make me miss my 8 pm window. What window, you ask? Any self-respecting, oota-loving Ooru resident knows that 8pm Tuesday is for trying one's luck at Guerilla Diner, which has just 12 seats and arguably the best burgers in town. Almost 8. I checked the website on my laptop. Booking window

NARU NOODLE BAR, BENGALURU

Seats 20
Reservation opens Monday 8 pm, sold out by 8:10 pm
Booking fee: ₹1,000 per person, redeemable

"Thanks to micro diners, people who dreamt of having a restaurant can actually open one"

Chef Kavan Kuttappa



opened. By 8:02 pm, the slots for week-ends and 8-10 pm were gone. There were only five seats left for 7 pm Wednesday. I clicked, paid ₹1,000 for two seats, and it was done. Phew!

On Wednesday, we reached Guerilla Diner 15 minutes early. At 7, we crossed the purple door and black curtains into "the ghetto burger shop and taqueria". Chef Tushar Sood was at the grill behind the till managed by his father. For ₹113 more, we got a double-patty Oklahoma Fried Onion smash burger and a Filleting Nemo.

The food slapped, but the fastest-fingers-first frenzy was never part of Sood's original plan. His idea was to run Guerilla Diner as a "darshini"—a small, walk-in, self-service eatery common in Karnataka. But soon after it opened in 2024, its tiny kitchen was overwhelmed. People were waiting for two-three hours and the quality began to drop. After consulting fellow chef and micro-diner veteran Kavan Kuttappa of Naru Noodle Bar, Sood switched to reservations. Sales dropped by 40%. But reservations brought something else: predictable revenue, allowing him to plan his infrastructure and expenses.

SMALL IS BIG

Guerilla Diner is part of a larger shift away from the big, all-purpose restaurant with huge menus. Naru started in 2022 with eight seats; it now has 20. Kuttappa says diners were initially surprised by its size. Bengalureans now line up online to snag a table every Monday 8 pm.

"Restaurant dining before the pandemic was all about ambience and



GUERRILLA DINER, BENGALURU

Seats 12
Reservation opens Tuesday 8 pm, sold out by 8:20 pm
Booking fee: ₹500 per person, redeemable

"Shifting to reservations from walk-ins saw our sales drop by 40%. But fixed revenue has helped us plan better"

Chef Tushar Sood

Micro Diners, Maximum Demand

Some of the most talked-about restaurants are also the smallest. These under-20-seater, chef-led diners have people battling online for a reservation—for a culinary experience served with a side of social capital

RANNAGHOR BY SIENNA, KOLKATA

Seats 8
Booking opens 1st of every month
Price: ₹5,000 per person
Chefs: Koyel Roy Nandy, Avinandan Kundu

"You can't connect with 40 guests at once. But with a community-style tasting menu it's possible"

Chef Koyel Roy Nandy



of the room does not determine the experience. It has also lowered the entry barrier for restaurateurs. "It has pushed a lot of people who dreamt of having a restaurant to open one," says Kuttappa.

Small does not mean easy. Ebenezer started Farmlore with 12 seats, then worked through the economics and settled on 18. That number, he says, allows the chefs to time courses, personalise service and control the experience. "The smaller the number of people, the more control we have over the experience we are rendering."

At A Table in the Hills, Martins calls the format his "creative lab". Twelve diners allow him to experiment, build detail into the experience and work without the constraints of a conventional restaurant. "Table in the Hills gives me the liberty to go all out as a chef. There are no boundaries because it's a table of 12."

For Rannaghor's chef Koyel Roy Nandy, the appeal is also about telling a story. "You can't con-

nect with 40 guests at once. But with a community-style tasting menu it's possible." Her eight-seater allows her and chef Avinandan Kundu to explore food, communities and the ecosystem around Bengali cuisine in a way they believe would be difficult at scale.

The control is precisely what makes the format attractive to chefs. Increasingly, it is what diners are paying for.

CHEF IS THE STAR

At Papa's, Shahzad's kitchen and dining room are effectively the same space. The restaurant was born out of necessity. An 800 sq ft space inside Jude Bakery in Bandra dictated the concept. "There is no real kitchen and dining room—you are in my kitchen. It is actually the dining room," he says. The spatial constraint has become a feature. "In a 12-seat restaurant, you have the power to wow with impact," says Shahzad. He can cook in the moment, change the menu when he wants and treat the restaurant as "the purest form of expression".

For diners, the proximity changes the experience. Mumbai-based Nowshad Rizwanullah had found Papa's impossible to get. He eventually got lucky when someone invited him. "What made Papa's special was that you are sitting with the chef right there. You can tell he's enjoying this. And that



What's a micro-diner?

Small-format restaurants, typically seating no more than 20 people. Usually chef-led, they favour focused menus, intimate settings and reservation-led dining

Why is it popular?

- Leaner, efficient operations
- Chefs have freedom to experiment
- Enables immersive dining
- Exclusivity creates buzz
- Customers value food over grand spaces

A TABLE IN THE HILLS, GOA

Seats 12 (min 6 persons)
Price: ₹6,000

"People come to a micro diner as much for exclusivity as for food"

Chef Avinash Martins



currency. Aparna Balaji, a risk consultant,

has been trying for Naru for eight months, setting alarms and refreshing the booking page. "Ironically, I'm better at booking a tatkal train ticket than a table at Naru!" she jokes. For her, scarcity is part of the appeal. "The difficulty makes getting a table feel rewarding."

For Mumbai-based screenwriter and editor Anagh Mukherjee, the motivation is the chef, not social media. He has been trying to get into Papa's for almost a year and has an alarm set for 11 am on September 1, when reservations open next. "It's the promise of the food," he says. A fan of Shahzad's cooking, he sees the tasting menu as a value experience. "I think premium dining experiences like this are equivalent to a concert: you are watching a maestro conduct service right in front of you."

Bengaluru-based Prashanth Chandrasekhar, founder of art studio Craftsmen Inc, says he was initially drawn to Guerilla by the hype and the difficulty of getting in. "After all, it's the forbidden fruit which is the tastiest."

Scarcity, however, can backfire, too. Psychotherapist Sandra Manoj, who eventually made it to Naru, says the anticipation put pressure on the experience. "The process feels intentionally gate-kept and ultimately disproportionate to the reward."

Mahendra agrees that scarcity alone cannot sustain a restaurant. "It may create initial curiosity, but the dining experience is what determines whether people continue to engage with the restaurant." If the food does not deliver, it will not work.

The absurdity of the scramble has now become a joke. In March, Bengaluru comedians Yuck Collective launched Reservation Gym, a mock website where diners can practise filling out forms to snag hard-to-get tables. Founders Hari Krishna, Neelakash Mathur and Vijith VS say the idea came from their own frustration. "At this point, we felt scarcity was becoming part of the hype around these restaurants. But when access becomes too difficult, that friction becomes a problem for the customer."

The old restaurant sold a big room, a long menu and plenty of choice. The micro-diner offers something more finite: a seat, a story, the chef's attention and the feeling of being part of something not everyone can access. As Rizwanullah puts it, "The fact that it is rare augments the experience. If Papa's were more accessible, would we have enjoyed it as much? Maybe not."

Diners may complain about impossible reservations, but they are also setting reminders to land them. The room may be smaller. The stakes have become bigger.

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The Bar Consultants. "Earlier Indian diners would measure the success of a restaurant by its size and whether the menu ran to 50 or 80 dishes. The interest today lies in authenticity, skill, craftsmanship and the story behind the food. Guests value intention."

Ebenezer says it shows in the behaviour of guests. They arrive on time, read the FAQs and understand the format. "They know that if they arrive at 7 pm for a 6:30 pm service, they will miss out on courses. They take food much more seriously now," he says.

Scarcity of seats is part of the appeal. Says Chachra: "Scarcity has become one of the strongest marketing tools in hospitality, but it works only when it is genuine. In a 14- or 16-seater, limited availability is the reality of the business, and over time it naturally creates anticipation. So much so that securing a table begins to feel very different from booking a regular dinner."

THE FOMO FACTOR

For Bengaluru-based media professional Fathima Ashraf, getting into Naru required preparation worthy of a competitive exam. She had been trying for nearly a year and was shocked when her husband got it on the first try. "The anticipation is part of the experience. When I managed a seat, I felt a sense of victory," she says. When she posted a story from inside Naru, she was flooded with messages: How did you get it? Is there a hack? How is the food?

The scarcity carries its own social

PAPA'S, MUMBAI

Seats 12
Booking opens 1st of every month, avg waiting period 45-60 days
Price of tasting menu: ₹8,000

"The beauty of running a 12-seater is that you have the power to wow"

Chef Hussain Shahzad



FARMLORE, BENGALURU

Seats 18
Booking opens 90 days in advance
Lunch: ₹4,200 per person
Dinner: ₹6,825 per person

"The format creates loyalty, not just hype"

Chef Johnson Ebenezer

Dia Rekhi | Auroville

Nestled in the red earth and the dry evergreen forest of Auroville is the Dana Community. It is the de facto address of most of the pottery studios and kilns in this experimental township, about 12 km from Puducherry.

Auroville's pottery community, spanning almost 15 distinct local studios, training centres and cooperatives, is known for its studio ceramics and glazed stoneware.

But now the kilns are lying cold. Ever since the war broke out in Iran, affecting gas supply and hiking fuel prices, Auroville's shelves are groaning under the weight of greenware—bisque-fired plates, thrown teapots and hand-sculpted stoneware mugs—waiting for their final trial by fire.

A high-fire glaze guzzles gas. A big kiln typically requires 10 LPG cylinders of 19 kg each for a single firing. And each cylinder now costs around ₹3,000, up from about ₹1,700 before the war.

CEASE FIRE

Firings are now rationed. The clay is waiting. While fuel supply has somewhat stabilised since the peak of the crisis in March, Auroville's potters are wringing their hands.

"In March, it was very difficult as LPG cylinders were not available," says Tosha Parmar, a ceramic artist at Mandala Pottery, one of Auroville's large pottery studios. "Now, things are better but it is still not back to normal. Fuel prices have gone up and artisans have had to increase the prices of their products."

Stoneware and tableware may be the last thing people would like to buy as these are not essentials, she says. However, their studio has been somewhat insulated from the crisis as its recent focus has been on sculptures, which require more wood firing than gas firing. "We have a big show coming up where Adil Writer [partner at Mandala Pottery] is showcasing his works so we are all busy doing more sculptures and murals than the regular cups and mugs. We are doing wood firings almost every day because sculptures require that but even the prices of wood have gone up," she adds.

Next door, at Flame Pottery, run by Michel Hutin, cost is again the biggest pain point. To offset the rising costs, he will have to go for an 8% price hike, but he does not want to do that. "I've been doing

this work for decades. At one point we were exporting most of our tableware. Today, my customers are mostly Indian cafes and restaurants, especially in Auroville and Goa. Raising prices for them is not an option for me and so I've decided to absorb the losses," he says.

Hutin's studio has two big kilns. Each one requires 10 cylinders of 19 kg each for a firing. He says the studio would generally do one large firing a month with around 800 pieces of tableware stacked up in the kiln. "Now our work has no regularity or security and I've stopped keeping track of cylinder prices," he says.

REINVENTING THE WHEEL

Studio potters say this period has forced them to be more creative and

Cold, Cold

In Auroville, clay is waiting to be turned into tableware as fuel price hike forces pottery studios to ration the firing of kilns



Bhu Ceramics' Nausheen Bari in her studio



Kiln loaded with ceramics to be fired at Flame Pottery



Ceramic artist Tosha Parmar at Mandala Pottery



Rakhee Kane at the wheel

difficult and the risk of breakage and damage is quite high. Not many people do that but for me it just didn't make sense to do a double firing anymore."

"Everything has become more expensive which means we have to charge more," says Bari. "I have had to double the prices. That is a big challenge because in India ceramic doesn't have a market. People would use something like steel. This has drastically affected sales since March."

Bari is gearing up for an open studio sale in August, something she says she wouldn't normally do. "I'm just doing whatever I can to sell stuff because there's no money to do a firing," she says. "I'm not going to touch my wheel until I have some sales."

Artists say wood to fire sculptures has also become expensive

firing so I was not impacted much by the LPG crisis except for a short period when cylinders were not available. At that time I even did my bisque firings with wood. But now even wood has become expensive," she says.

Around two years ago, she would buy a tonne of wood for around ₹7,000. Today, she says, it costs ₹13,000 per tonne, which is what she requires for one firing. "I cannot make cups and mugs and saucers when wood costs so much," she says. "The economics don't work out for tableware. It

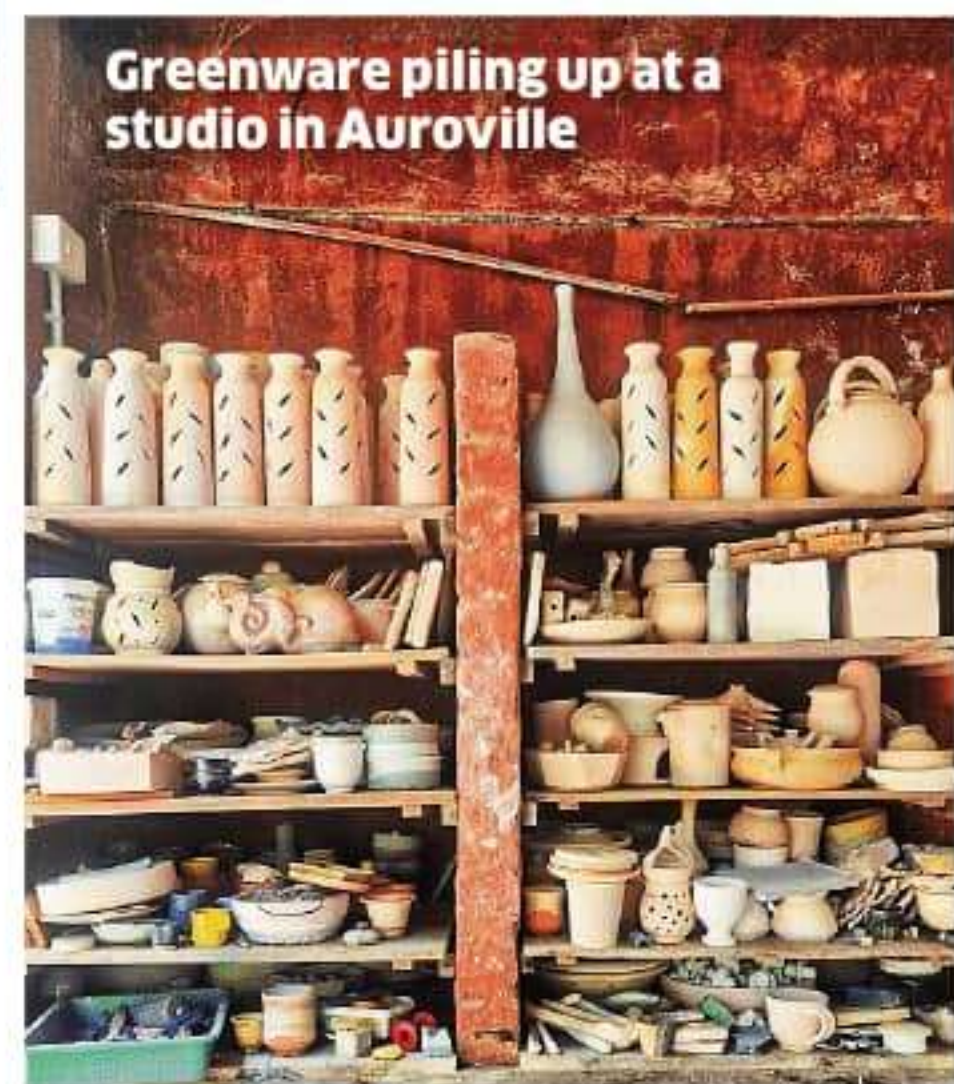
only makes sense if I do sculptures which I can price well to offset the cost."

Others like Sabrina Srinivas, founder of Kalabhumi Pottery Studio, have decided to change tack. "I have a solo show coming up in January, so when the fuel situation got bad, I decided to change course," she says. "I generally follow a cycle of three months of making and two weeks of glazing and firing. Following the war, I did six months of making. I will begin the firing cycle in September. As a studio potter, I have had some flexibility in choosing projects that I could fulfil alongside my work for the show."

In September, she will have to do multiple firings which will require many gas cylinders. Her concern is availability. "Fuel prices have come down from what they were in March, but supply is still limited. By September I hope things will stabilise even further," she says.

Cold kilns truly are a ceramic artist's worst nightmare.

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Greenware piling up at a studio in Auroville

the preliminary bisque firing, after which they apply glaze and do another firing. Last week, I did a single firing with the glaze on. Applying glaze to a raw pot is very

fuel-efficient. Nausheen Bari, owner of Bhu Ceramics, says everyone is more fuel-conscious and cost-aware. Now potters are firing kilns to 1,240°C rather than 1,300°C,

which makes a difference in terms of fuel consumption. "We have had to revamp and rethink the entire process," says Bari. "Generally, potters do two firings—

Even wood prices have gone up, says Rakhee Kane, founder of Aavartan Pottery. "I am a sculptor and I primarily do wood firings. I use a small gas kiln only for bisque

Stranded in the Strait of Hormuz



For 75 days, **RAMAN KAPOOR**, an Indian tanker captain, and his crew were anchored in a war zone with missiles criss-crossing overhead. He writes about the long wait to return home from the Strait of Hormuz:

I didn't get the first warning from an email or a company circular. I got it from the local pilot at an Iraqi port. It was early morning. Cargo ops were done. The pilot was climbing down the ladder when he paused and said quietly, "Captain, there's trouble." Two hours later the office confirmed it. War had started.

I'm a seasoned Indian master of an oil tanker; at sea for over 28 years. We were stranded in the Strait of Hormuz for almost two and a half months due to heightened regional tensions and restricted transit advisories.

It's been a blur; to be honest, February 28 was just another day and then, suddenly, we were in the middle of a war zone. The uncertainty was overwhelming. The first few hours were about trying to understand what was happening and finding a safe place to wait.

VACATE THE BERTH

The instructions came fast from port authorities: Vacate berth. Shift to safe anchorage within port limits. Do not proceed out. Await further orders.

Immediately I mustered all 23 crew members on the bridge. The youngest was 21. The oldest, our bosun, had 30 years at sea.

I broke the war news to them: war is here. We'll shift to safe anchorage for now. We will follow every instruction. We will stay together. We will get through this.

No one asked questions instantly. At sea, you learn to listen first. But later there were loads of questions and concerns. Psychologically, my crew was devastated. 110,000 MT of cargo was still on board. The ship felt heavy.

ANCHORED IN A WAR ZONE

The irony is that the work never stops even when the ship isn't moving. We still did rounds. Still checked tanks, generators, fire systems. Still cooked, cleaned and kept the engine room on standby. Daily life onboard remained almost the same.

But the crew remained fearful and under constant stress.

Regular meetings, security and safety drills had become routine. Every morning, 0800, security brief. Every afternoon: fire, abandon ship, missile strike! We drilled for things we prayed would never happen.

The bridge was manned 24 hours. Not for navigation—we weren't going anywhere. But for watching. For listening to VHF radio. For

counting naval boats circling the anchorage and missiles flying over us.

What kept our lives smooth was the internet. Unbroken. WhatsApp calls to wives, to mothers, to kids. "We are fine. Don't worry." We all said the same line. We all knew it wasn't true.

Morale comes from routine and teamwork.

CORRIDOR OF UNCERTAINTY

My crew was under constant stress and devastated. There was no safe way out. No corridor, no escort, no plan.

The uncertainty was the worst part—no body could say if we would be stuck for five days or five months. Prolonged stay meant missing family celebrations, folks panicking at home and young sailors asking if they would make it back at all.

You can't switch off stress. The impact on mental health is severe, with anxiety and depression due to extended stay at sea and delayed repatriation.

My crew was under constant stress and devastated. There was no safe way out. No corridor, no escort, no plan. The uncertainty was the worst part—nobody could say if we would be stuck for five days or five months

What helped us get through? Two things. First, the crew itself. We became each other's family. We conducted extra drills to stay focused, held mess-room prayers and took turns talking to the junior guys through night watches. Second, the knowledge that if we stopped, global supply would. That sense of duty kept us going.

But while we remained safe at anchorage, we heard several stories that broke us. Seafarers' losses that broke us. Seafarers' lives on other ships. Crews being disowned by companies. No regular supplies of food and water. No wages for months. No repatriation. Many ships received pressure from owners to sail through the Strait of Hormuz—"Commercial pressure," they called it. As if cargo was more urgent than life.

FEAR HAD A NEW SOUND

And then the worst fear manifested. We were at the dinner table when we heard the blast. A dull thud, then a flash on the port side. Close. Very close. Less than a mile away. The whole ship shook. Coffee cups jumped off tables.

For a few seconds, which felt like eternity, no one spoke. Then the alarms, the shouting on VHF, naval boats moving...

After that day, fear had a new sound. It was the silence between explosions. Over the next weeks we heard hundreds of explosions. We saw missiles flying over our heads. We felt tremors through the hull.

Sleepless nights and restless days became

THREE KEY ASKS

1. CODIFY SAFE CORRIDORS:

Adopt a mandatory conflict evacuation convention, with pre-designated, internationally protected routes in and out of high-risk zones, triggered automatically when conflict starts

2. MAKE SEAFARER WELFARE ENFORCEABLE:

Amend the Maritime Labour Convention to include 'Right to Refuse War Zone Transit' with full pay protection and job security. If IMO says safety comes first, put it in ink—and penalise flags and owners who violate it

3. COUNT PUBLICLY, IN REAL TIME:

Launch an IMO Seafarers in Distress dashboard, with live numbers of trapped ships, crew, flag, location. Because what IMO tracks, governments rescue.



part of our lives. Living on the edge with constant fear of life.

BREAKING POINT

Then came the order we didn't expect. Office: "Carry out STS operation with another vessel in anchorage." The whole crew refused.

I understood why. The last vessel we had seen attacked was also engaged in a similar ship-to-ship (STS) cargo transfer. No one wanted to be alongside another ship with hoses connected and nowhere to run, should bombs come calling.

The office kept instructing. "It's company interest. It's urgent."

After many requests, the office ensured our security: naval boat patrolling during operation, standby boat ready and special bonus for all crew.

It subsequently went safe and well. Thirty-six hours alongside. Every 15 minutes, we looked up at the sky.

By now, exhaustion had set in. The crew was on the edge of mutiny. There were thoughts of resignation, because war wasn't ending and the crew was not getting a positive response for their repatriation.

Back home, our families were under constant stress. There was little they could do except pray.

The drills felt pointless. The VHF chatter was just noise. The internet calls home got shorter because what was there to say except "still here".

I filed for sign-off every week. "Crew overdue. Request relief." Reply: "Trying, Captain. No one is willing to join."

Materially, we rationed. Fresh provisions ran low. We stretched fuel, water and medicines because resupply meant sailing

through contested waters. The internet was patchy. So families got rumours before they got us.

GOOD NEWS

Finally, on May 12, good news came. Relief confirmed. I signed off from the ship on May 14.

Seventy-five days anchored inside a war zone. I should have felt only happiness. And I did. But I also felt sad for my mates still on ship, still awaiting to go home. Leaving part of your crew behind. You don't celebrate until everyone's home. I hugged the chief engineer at the gangway. "You'll be next," I told him. I hope I was right.

My crew is still stuck. How many others? The world doesn't know because we don't report it.

My exit can't be the end of the story. We need a global protocol to get every trapped ship out—not just the lucky few who find a suitable reliever.

LOOKING BACK

People ask me what it was like to command a merchant vessel during war. It wasn't like in the movies. There was no hero moment. No dramatic escape.

It was 75 days of waiting. Of drilling. Of watching the sky. Of making decisions that aren't in any manual: Do we refuse STS? Do we tell the crew the whole truth? Do we keep going when everyone is tired? We also witnessed violation of ceasefire. And false promises by the company.

It showed me how fragile our system is. When the world goes to war, the world still needs oil, food and goods. And someone has to stay with the ship to deliver it. That someone is us: merchant mariners. We are invisible

THE MORNING BRIEF PODCAST

75 Days in a War Zone



A tanker captain remembers his time trapped in the Strait of Hormuz, with his crew near breaking point.

Tune in to **ETPlay.com**. Available on **EconomicTimes.com/podcast**, **Amazon Prime Music**, **Apple Podcasts**, **JioSaavn** and **Spotify**.

The Great Restoration

This year, arguably for the first time, restored Indian classics have made it to the top four international film festivals—from Cannes to TIFF

Restored Indian movies are drawing a new crowd

Faizal Khan

A three-decade-old Indian film will share screen space with the works of some of the most influential filmmakers at the Venice Film Festival in September: Dev Benegal's *English, August* (1994) is part of Venice Classics, alongside movies by Luis Buñuel, Roberto Rossellini and Andrzej Wajda.

Later in the month, as the film festival circuit moves to Canada, the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) will screen John Abraham's *Amma Ariyan* (1986) in the Toronto Classics section.

This year, possibly for the first time, restored Indian films have made it to the top four international film festivals—Cannes, Venice, Berlin and Toronto—landing a big moment for Indian cinema.

Earlier, Pradip Krishen's *In Which Annie Gives It Those Ones* (1989), starring Arundhati Roy in writer's role and leading

role, was shown in the Berlinale Classics at the Berlin Film Festival. And *Amma Ariyan* was a big draw at the Cannes Film Festival's Cannes Classics in May.

While the rare feat of restored Indian movies getting selected to the biggest festivals of the era is a celebratory moment, it also draws attention to the dire need of conserving thousands of films in danger of being lost forever.

SCREEN SAVER

Over the past decade and half, film restoration has been making its mark in India. It mirrors a global trend in which film conservation has emerged as a multi-billion-dollar industry, due to the high cost involved in maintaining

the quality and integrity of a movie.

Indian classics have been in a state of despair for a long time. Prints of decades-old movies are in varying degrees of decay, deterioration and disintegration due to a frightening mix of factors like fire, flood, humidity and sheer neglect. "Film is a fragile medium that is prone to scratches, vinegar syndrome (chemical decay) and deterioration over time unless kept in optimum conditions," says Shivendra Singh Dungarpur, whose



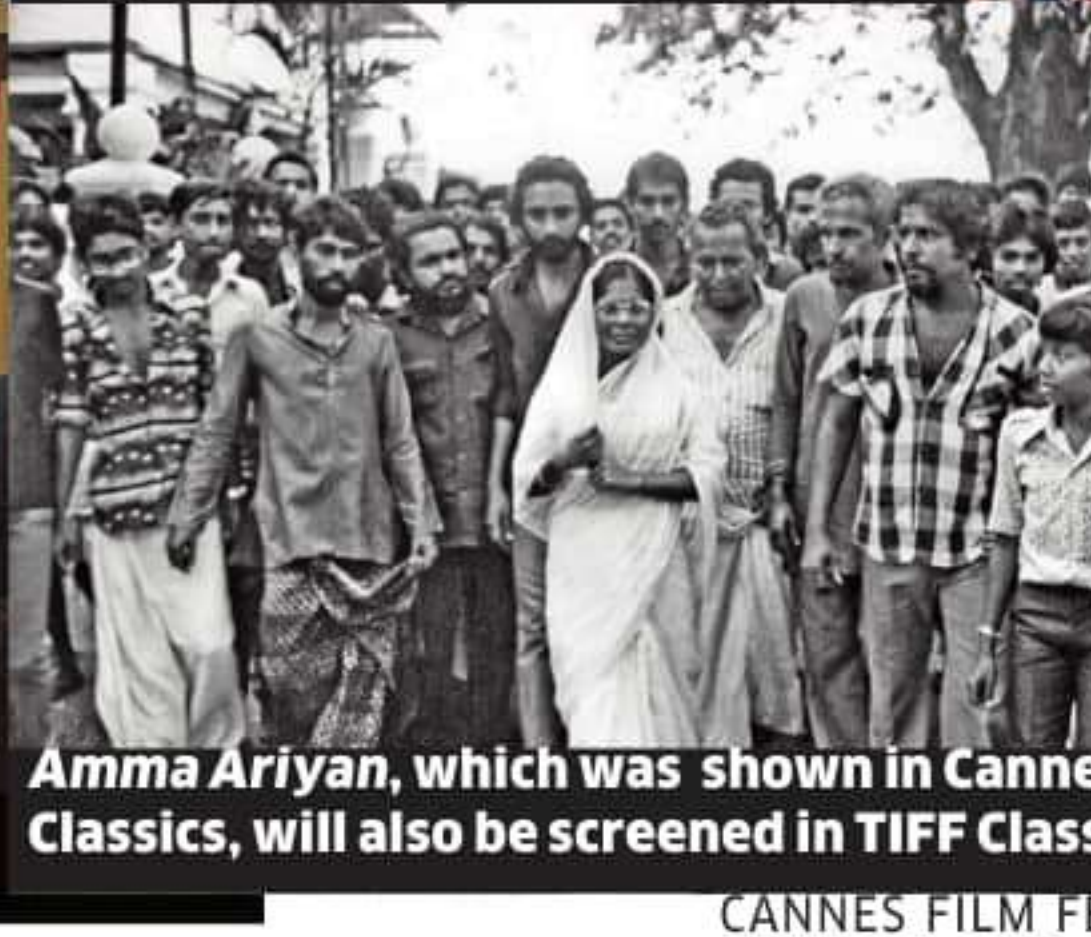
English, August will be screened in Venice Classics at the Venice Film Festival

Mumbai-based Film Heritage Foundation has restored both *Amma Ariyan* and *English, August*. "Sadly, in India with its track record of neglect and complacency, most films are in a very poor condition."

The need for conserving Indian classics was felt keenly when Satyajit Ray received the Academy Award for Lifetime Achievement in 1992. It was then that the world of cinema realised its horror that most of Ray's films were in poor condition. Alarmed by this discovery,



In Which Annie Gives It Those Ones was screened in Berlinale Classics



Amma Ariyan, which was shown in Cannes Classics, will also be screened in TIFF Classics

master negatives (original camera roll) of Ray's films were shipped to Henderson's Film Laboratories in London for safe storage.

However, disaster struck when a massive nitrate fire broke out in Henderson's lab in 1993, burning many classics, including Ray's Apu Trilogy. The Academy Film Archive began a desperate attempt to save Ray's films. Engineers from Italy's L'Immagine Ritrovata—one of the best film restoration labs in the world—spent thousands of hours salvaging them from the remains. In 2015, the restored Apu's Trilogy had its world premiere at New York's Museum of Modern Art.

Mughal-e-Azam (1960) was the first Indian film to be digitally restored for a theatrical release in 2004. Five years later, American filmmaker Martin Scorsese's Film Foundation restored and screened a rare Indian movie for a global audience—Uday Shankar's *Kalpavriksha* (1948).

CONSERVATION AS MISSION

In 2009, India launched a major initiative to digitally restore old movies from prints available at the National Film Archive of India (NFAD), Pune. The first film to be restored under the mission was Mrinal Sen's *Khandhar* (1983), which was shown in Cannes Classics. Significantly, all of Sen's films have been digitally restored. Other restored movies include a 1937 Tamil film, *Ambikapathy*, and a 1958 Hindi action film, *Ten O'Clock*.

In 2015, the Centre announced the National Film Heritage Mission, promising to restore 2,200 films across

languages. Among the films digitally restored are all the eight works of Ritwik Ghatak. In June this year, six of the films were screened at Cinema Ritrovato, a festival of restored movies in Italy, to celebrate Ghatak's birth centenary.

The success of Scorsese's Film Foundation in conserving cinema across the world resulted in a major private initiative in India in 2014—Dungarpur's Film Heritage Foundation. The combined efforts of the Film Foundation, Film Heritage Foundation, the central government and the film industry in preserving India's cinematic heritage are beginning to show results.

With *English, August*, a restored Indian film will be shown in Venice Classics for the third year in a row—it follows Bimal Roy's *Do Bigha Zamin* and Girish Kasaravalli's *Ghatashraddha*. Two out of seven films in TIFF Classics last year were from India—Ray's *Aranyer Din Ratri* and Ramesh Sippy's *Sholay* (1975). A restored Indian film has been featured in Cannes Classics for five straight years since 2022. As Gerald Duchaussoy, head of Cannes Classics, told the reporter earlier this year: "It has been a fantastic collaboration with India, which is ideal in the framework of what we are trying to promote—arthouse movies and at the same time accessible films, which will appeal to the audience today."

Restoration is creating new audiences for Indian classics at home and abroad, drawing a young crowd to old movies. As Dev Benegal says, "Restoration is more than preserving a film. It is the preservation of a conversation across generations."

The writer is a Delhi-based journalist

NEVER MIND THE TYPE, SWARAJ IS YOUR BIRYANI & YOU SHALL HAVE IT!

From Hyderabad to Kolkata, and Awadhi to Chettinad, the badshah of food has many avatars and disputed origin stories – that all make it a delicious lesson in India’s talent for being one as well as many

JUGULAR VEIN



JUG SURAIYA

A colourful roadside advertising kiosk in Gurgaon caught my eye. It featured a close-up of a copper patila of Hyderabad biryani, each golden grain of basmati aglow in succulent detail as an imagined symphony of spices suffused the monsoon-laden air with an ambrosial aroma. The ad was for a kitchen appliance, the USP of which was that unlike other devices of a similar nature that cook one dish at a time, this could cook two dishes simultaneously. Ek ticket, do mazaa. The next kiosk for the same appliance depicted Bombay biryani, looking equal-

ly delectable. The third kiosk showed Awadhi biryani, and the one after that, Calcutta biryani, each vying with the other for appetising appeal. This blitzkrieg of biryani was puzzling. If the idea behind the ads was to highlight the culinary ambidexterity of the 2-in-1 device, wouldn't it have made more persuasive sense to have had a sequence of different dishes like, say, dal makhani, matar paneer, or baingan bharta, instead of a repetitive quartet of biryanis? And then it struck me. The four biryanis were, in fact, four distinct and different dishes, in respect of some of the ingredients used, the recipes followed, and the places they came from. While they were all subsumed under the generic rubric of biryani, they differed from each other in much the same way as a Jamini Roy is different from an Amrita Sher-Gil, and both from a FN Souza. In that sense, the collective term biryani is reflective of the Indian ethos itself, which in its overarching Indianness incorporates individuated identities, such as Bengali, Marathi, Malayali, and Punja-



INDIA À LA CARTE

bi, inter alia, all belonging to the great joint family called Indians. Similarly, the biryani baradari has some 50 offshoots. There's the Hyderabad ver-

boiled eggs and potatoes. The Bombay variant, which also has potatoes but omits the eggs. A Kerala biryani. A Chettinad biryani. Not one, but two biryanis from Karna-

afied in the form of Myanmar danpauk, Indonesian kebuli, and Thai khao mhook. The putative origins of biryani are almost as numerous as its recipes. The word 'biryani' itself is said to trace its etymology to the Persian 'biryan' or 'beriyān', meaning to fry or roast, which, according to one dictionary, is related to the Sanskrit 'bhr̥jati', which has the same meaning. Was the precursor of biryani — ur-biry-

rich and aromatic Mogol Bringes [biryani] being sold in tented bazaars. Even the austere and ascetic Aurangzeb was not impervious to the tantalising seductiveness of the dish, mentioning in an admonitory letter to his son Bahadur Shah, 'I wanted to have from you... Sali-man who cooks 'biryani', but you did not allow him to serve as my cook. If you hap-pen to find a pupil of his, skillful in the art

Biryani's an alimentary iteration of eclectic individualism, which gives you total freedom of choice

ni, as it were — an early form of the US army's K-ration, a WW2 daily field package devised as a meal-in-one convenience food for soldiers on the march, as some food historians would persuade us? Or can it be traced to haute cuisine of the Mughal court dating back to Abul Fazl's late 16th c. Ain-i-Akbari, which features several references to the dish and ways of preparing it? A Portuguese priest who travelled to Lahore during the reign of Shah Jahan in the 17th c. mentions in his journal 'the

of cooking, you will send him to me.' Whatever its provenance, imperial kitchen or military encampment, and however heterogeneous its regional incarnations, and whether its ambience be a roadside dhaba or a gala 5-star banquet, biryani remains an alimentary iteration of eclectic individualism, which gives you total freedom of choice. To paraphrase a famous proclamation of inde-pendent resolve — swaraj is my biryani, and I shall have it!

RED HERRING



INDRAJIT HAZRA

Jai Hind Starts At Your Neck Of the Woods

Independence Days can be free-er if neighbourhood replaces country

Every 15th August, I get very emotional, even teary-eyed. The thought of everyone else enjoying a holiday on Independence Day — sometimes, even a long weekend — while I have a usual workday, cuts me up finer than chopped onions slipped into a twice-born's diet as statutorily warned in the Manusmriti. But not this year, quiches! Falling on a Saturday, my regular day off, with the first half of a Sunday to recover, yesterday was a rare 15th August when I was just like everyone else — patriotically aligned to raise a few tumblers to thank now-dead Britons for getting the Mysore pak out of India in 1947 after some 200 years of asset-stripping and super PR ('Bringing you civilisation never felt so Kipling'). It may not be the most genuine form of showing love for one's nitpicking and country, but the very fact that Independence Day is a special chhutti has to be branding genius that no uncolonised country can ever fathom. For my parents and his generation though — my father was 7 and my mother 5 on August 15, 1947 — Independence Day 1.0 was a palpable thing. On that day 79 years ago, and for some more years that followed, they realised that something special had happened. Because the grown-ups were celebrating like India had won the World Cup. Celebration was spontaneous, so that even the horrors of Partition couldn't completely dampen spirits. Not even for grown-ups who could actually comprehend the horrors if they chose to. But over the decades, 15th August became another Karva Chauth, with the nation replacing the husband, and every Indian a dutiful wife wishing the country's welfare in terms of GDP, greater global influence, loud meaningful singing in praise of Bharat Bhagya Vidhata — now also joined by Mataram — and hoisting the tricolour, instead of being hoisted by some petard, which sounds like a politer way of saying, 'Har Ghar Ti-ranga'. But move away from the 'Fun Day of Soviet Activities' and what 15th August has also turned into, while keeping up with the Jhunjhualas next door, is a short getaway, a drive to the hills, a special pizza meal, a dhamaka sale, a day at the cinema... essentially, what happy consumers would want a special day to be for planting a paper flag on the car dashboard. Because if yesterday wasn't really about either celebrating the departure of a bunch of guests who had abused and overstayed their welcome some 80 years ago, or about 'feeling free' more than on any other day, what was it about? Paying homage to our 'freedom fighters', noble as it must be, seems more like school homework than Yaa! celebration that one would think Independence Day to be. Perhaps, the trick is to scale things down. Instead of thinking only 'Hail country!' in all its lovely abstraction, maybe celebrating our immediate neighbourhood would be more actively tangible? Not just peddle pranaam to statues and frames portraits — including of the one who adorns all our banknotes — but revel in the things immediately around us: the gorgeous phuchka-golgappa at the mouth of the road; the planetary monsoon skyline from the window; those puppies cavorting under cars who suddenly turn into heaps of sleep; top of trees visible from the balcony that become a green Sridevi sari in the breeze; the kids practising aiki-do moves in the neighbourhood park; even the insides of our homes that we fashion in our own images... This is the tangible 'country' we inhabit, the 'desh' we belong to, which in turn belongs to us, for which we harbour a deep taken-for-granted fondness. Not as grandiose as patriotism — a word hammered into shape from 'pater', in the sense of 'father-land' — but an unbidden, unprompted pull for where we stay, where we are, where we feel free-ly, without any need for stage directions. And for this, you don't need an Independence Day, holiday or no holiday. All you have to do is look out of the window, take a walk around the block, drive to the local khana-peena, sit back in your living room... It's always Jai Hind somewhere.

indrajit.hazra@timesofindia.com

How to Take Joy Out of Jumping Red Lights

Prepaid fines could make traffic violators think twice – and let the state, Kautilya-style, collect its dues gently

BARBS FROM THE BURBS



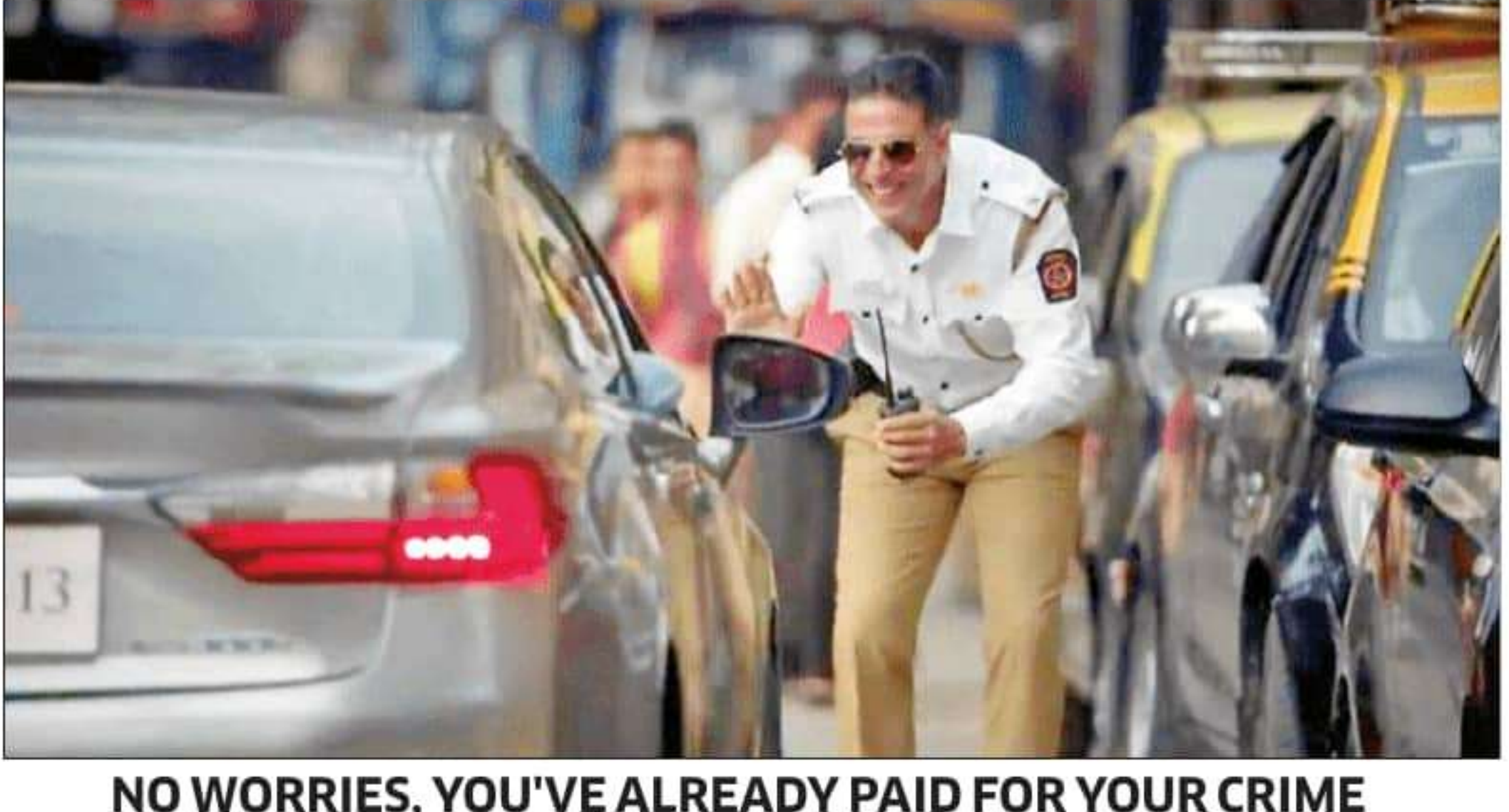
MADHAVAN NARAYANAN

'Art is anything you can get away with,' wrote Marshall McLuhan in his 1967 book, The Medium is the Massage. The quote has also been attributed to Andy Warhol. Neither media theorist nor pop artist was speaking about unpaid traffic fines. But they might as well have. Rule-breaking is evidently a high art in the low-life roads of Delhi-NCR. Only the other day, I saw a new Delhi government bus speeding on its way to the nearest metro station, neatly jumping a red light at the Delhi-Noida border. Will the driver pay the fine from one arm of the state to the other? Delhi and UP account for an unpaid amount of ₹22,000 or in traffic fines linked to e-challans, split roughly evenly between the two. These two states also account for more than half of the country's unpaid traffic e-challans. According to Gol, Tamil Nadu is a comparable good-boy state that issued 6.37 cr e-challans, but had a much higher strike rate in recovery, with only ₹2,122 or in unpaid dues. Delhi and UP between them issued about 13 cr e-challans. Much like penalty corners in football, we need to get down to strike rates

in this new-age phenomenon in which CCTV cameras and mobile-linked challans are meant to cut down on the work and the presence of traffic cops. Ground realities are different. Alas, behavioural science comes in the way of half-baked e-governance. People are not the same everywhere. Which is why you need a horses-for-courses approach. Apparently, reasons for e-challans not working in the capital are not only the nature and extent of violations, but also a broader driving culture and behaviour after challans are issued. Accumulation of fines and larger e-challans adds to the woes. There is a way out. Look no further than highway toll plazas and airport parking lots for guidance. The pre-

paid, rechargeable RFID (radio frequency identification) stickers are affixed to a windscreen. Overhead readers capture the tag's unique ID and deduct the exact fee to raise the barrier. Prepaid fines can do the same trick. Before citizens are outraged, one may add that prepaid amounts may be paid at a decent interest rate. The point is that the artists who think they can get away with rule-breaking have a rough idea of what it costs government authorities to levy a legitimate fine in terms of human effort, court hearings, and accompanying official procedures. Turn the whole thing on its head, and the onus of proof shifts from beady-eyed babus to clever drivers, or, in alliterative Hindi, to chalaak chaalaks.

Onus of proof shifts from beady-eyed babus to clever drivers, or chalaak chaalaks

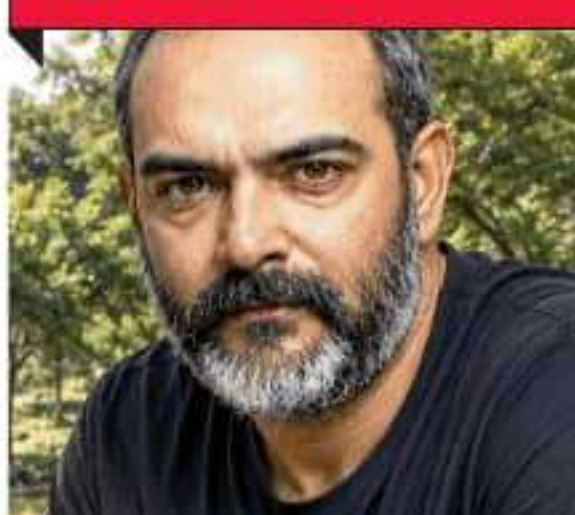


NO WORRIES, YOU'VE ALREADY PAID FOR YOUR CRIME

Hold That Langurous Pose, AI Babulal

To keep monkeys away in our inflationary times, disruptive innovation is called for

MEMORY STICK



SIDDHARTH CHOWDHURY

Recently, while returning from a wet literary soiree, I was struck by a wondrous sight. On the walls of my apartment building in Gurgaon, spotlight in neon, a 6x4 ft image of a fierce, yet dolorous, langur had suddenly manifested. I was so stunned that I spent a few minutes in complete adoration. Going back and forth for a better angle, I finally retreated and sat down on an iron bench in front of the lobby entrance. Soon the night guard, Om-bir, joined me. He smiled and said, 'It is so lifelike, isn't it, sir-ji?' 'Yes,' I agreed, 'but why this Hanuman-ji?' 'For the monkeys, sir-ji. They are terrified of langurs. After seeing this poster, they won't visit our society.' He added, 'Babulal's rates are high this season. More monkeys are coming out of the Aravallis. We can't afford him anymore, the president has said.' 'Who's Babulal?' 'Babulal is the langur we get from Badshahpur. His rates are now ₹5,000 for 3 hours, along with half a dozen carrots and three radishes.' 'That's not much. Even langurs need to eat, surely. Karamchand in my childhood loved carrots.' 'It's just that, sir-ji, Dharambir, his malik, is not picking up my phone anymore, because we have not cleared his dues for the last two times.' 'Rocky-ji thought of getting

this poster made.' Om-bir looked up at the walls admiringly. Rockyji, a chubby 14-year-old, is the president's son. He was chased by a mother monkey after he threw a tennis ball at a baby monkey. The baby monkey took the ball with it to the Aravallis. 'Where did he find this magnificent photograph? On the internet?' 'Oh no, sir, I took it with my iPhone 15 when Babulal spent Christmas with us. I edited the Santa cap off his head.' The guard showed the photo on his phone to me proudly.

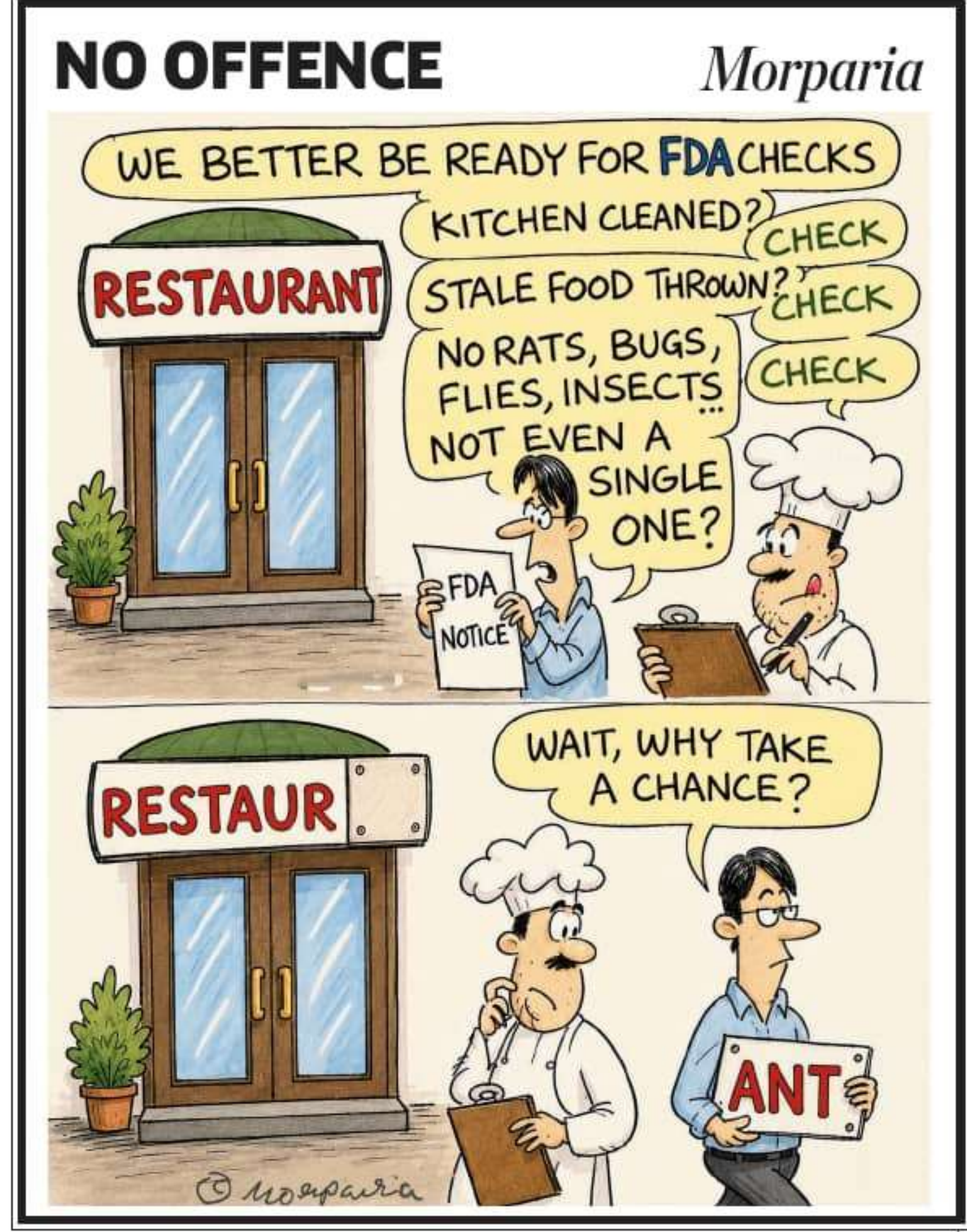
'Rocky-ji thought of getting this poster made'



IF YOU WANT TO CUT OUT THAT MONKEY BUSINESS

'So that's Babulal on the wall?' Yes, Om-bir reiterated. 'I thought he looked familiar. Like a celebrity you meet at an airport, but can't place. You are quite the photographer, Om-bir; a

regular David Bailey. You have captured the aloof-yet-ferocious quality of Babulal perfectly. It's like an author photograph on the back flap of a crime noir. Only the trench coat is missing.' 'Thank you, sir-ji. The print shop owner was also happy. He has printed 100 posters on flex boards. There is quite a demand from Gurgaon societies.' This is how AI works, I said to myself. Now the picture of Babulal is going to make Babulal redundant. Very soon he would starve in his garret in Badshahpur, and so would Dharambir. It would have been much better if Om-bir had worn a mask of a langur and chased the monkeys, like the UP police did a few years back, chasing robbers and making gunshot sounds — 'thain, thain' — because they had forgotten to carry bullets. This is AI for you. The ultimate jugaad. 'That's all well, Om-bir. But have you taken Babulal's consent for the use of his image? Actors like Salman Khan and Akshay Kumar have gone to court over the matter, and the courts have ruled in their favour.' 'Babulal's consent?' Om-bir looked horrified. Someone who had never asked for his wife's consent was now supposed to ask for a langur's? His mind reeled at the horror, the horror of it. Overcome, he sat down beside me on the bench. 'Yes, Babulal just might go to court if his posters start appearing all over Gurgaon. After all, in his field of expertise, he's no less a superstar than Salman Khan.' Planting this seed of anxiety in poor Om-bir's mind, which I was sure he would share with the RWA president, I made my way merrily up to my apartment. P.S. Last week, three men were hired to mimic langur sounds to keep monkeys away from the venue of Badminton World Championships in Delhi. Just saying.



ET Sunday Crossword 0181

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
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18							22
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30				31			

ACROSS

1 It could be grand if I dressed up, but it's demeaning (5,3)
5 Breather during exercise? It's what divers take (6)
9 Meet joker — Jack perhaps? (4,4)
10 They might be reduced in Spain but hold on to your cash (6)
12 Roadside inn not finished? It's only a speck (4)
13 Clairvoyant breaks athletic record indoors (10)
15 Beryl, say, is so cute swimming face down outside (8,5)

DOWN

1 Popular family ignore the Italian's notoriety (6)
2 Feature in paper covering excellent service (5)
3 Treetop cut to make bow (4)
4 Guy from Tel Aviv is in fact related to some people (7)
6 Fabric carefully crafted without them (5)
7 Huge robin bothered person close to me (9)
8 Anticipated spat after old rat left (8)
11 People at university get list of courses (4)
14 Unknown alien, one that's been reported in Tibet (4)
15 I hear play damaged guest's name appearing there (5,4)
16 Old monarch offers little resistance (3)
17 It's in southeastern location (4)
18 Support distressed Poles travelling round States (8)
20 Like crime films, somewhat historic on reflection (4)
21 Piece of film shown by expert at gallery (7)
22 Carpenter's nail, for instance? (6)
24 Put up with papers in Lincoln (5)
26 Left one and sipped once? It makes you furious (5)
27 Mum loves chase (4)

ET

© The Daily Mail

UK PM Calls Jason Arday's Death 'a Tragedy'

LONDON: UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham said on Saturday the death of black academic Jason Arday, who resigned from Cambridge University amid a plagiarism scandal that sparked racism claims, was "a tragedy on so many levels". Arday, 41, was found dead on Friday, just over a week after he quit his positions as university professor and Jesus College fellow following both institutions announcing probes into various accusations against him. His family criticised what they called a "campaign of harassment" that followed the allegations about his academic work and personal life, while Arday himself had said that campaign was "racially motivated". — Reuters

Spain Ignored Warnings of Migrant Rush

CEUTA In the weeks before a rush of more than 70,000 migrants into the Spanish enclave of Ceuta, border workers warned Spain's central government that more people, spurred on by social media, were arriving by sea, adding they feared an escalation. Spain's government did not heed their warnings and took little action, they said. A Spanish court ruling, published on June 29, stated migrants could only be pushed back from entering Ceuta if they crossed a physical barrier, specifying that anyone swimming to the enclave did not. Government blamed the deadly rush of July 29-30 on misinformation about the ruling spread by criminal networks. — Reuters

'Towards Alternate-fuel Vehicles'

From Page 1
The old petrol-versus-diesel equation is giving way to a market where multiple powertrains compete for the same customer. The scale of the shift is becoming harder to ignore. Federation of Automobile Dealers Association vice-president Sai Giridhar said consumer hesitation around the E20 transition had nudged some buyers towards CNG, hybrids and EVs. In July, the combined share of CNG, hybrid and electric passenger vehicles reached 40.59%, just 1.09 percentage points behind petrol at 41.68%. A year earlier, the gap was 13.21 percentage points. That narrowing gap is significant because the challenge to petrol is no longer coming from a single technology. CNG commands a sizeable share, while hybrids are attracting buyers seeking better fuel efficiency without giving up the convenience of an internal-combustion engine. EVs, too, are steadily gaining ground. "We do not see this as a long-term effect, as petrol sales have been seeing a slowdown of late and the direction has been towards alternate-fuel vehicles," said a senior executive at a leading carmaker. Carmakers are responding by keeping their options open rather than betting on a single technology. Maruti Suzuki is seeing strong traction in CNG while expanding into EVs and exploring other technologies. Hyundai is increasing its focus on CNG alongside EVs, petrol and diesel, while Tata Motors and Mahindra continue to build portfolios spanning electric and internal-combustion vehicles. Other manufacturers are similarly maintaining a mix of powertrains as they wait to see how consumer preferences evolve. For petrol, the implications are clear: E20 anxiety may be accelerating the shift, but the underlying change is broader.

Cooperative Federalism

From Page 1
The prime minister also touched upon issues ranging from youth skilling and cooperative federalism to drug abuse and the preparations for the 2036 Olympics. Under AI Youth Skilling, 10 million youth will be trained in AI over the next year through nationwide mission mode. Also, free online coaching will be offered to youth preparing for various examinations. Modi sought the involvement of youth in the ongoing Census exercise,

Hormuz Ship Attacks Mount as US Vows to Cripple Iran Economy

IN LINE OF FIRE 65 vessel incidents, 17 seafarer deaths reported amid conflict as of August 11

Bloomberg

Tehran: More ships have come under attack in the Strait of Hormuz as talks to end the war in the Middle East remain stalled and the US readies new economic measures to force Iran to capitulate. The UK Maritime Trade Operations on Saturday said it had been notified of a projectile striking the hull of a bulk carrier: Two Abu Dhabi National Oil Co vessels were struck while transiting Hormuz on Thursday and another was hit on Friday evening, according to reports from the United Arab Emirates' state-run WAM news agency. There were no reports of injuries. The waterway, through which a fifth of the world's oil and gas transited before the war, has emerged as a key sticking point in negotiations to bring a lasting end to almost six months of fighting. The US is adamant free passage along the route linking the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea should be restored, but Iran insists it will retain control. The price of Brent crude, the global benchmark, rose almost 6% this week as hopes faded of a quick resolu-

Iran Fires Back at Trump's Threat to Declare Hormuz a US Territory

Tehran: Iran on Saturday fired back at US President Donald Trump's claim that he would soon declare the Strait of Hormuz part of US territory, saying the crucial energy waterway it has blockaded "will remain Iranian". Trump has repeatedly said the strait is under US control — an assertion the Islamic re-

public denies. "The Strait of Hormuz has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian," Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said on X.



Israeli Airstrikes on Southern Lebanon Kill 11



BEIRUT: Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon killed at least 11 people on Saturday, in the deadliest attacks since a precarious truce between Israel and Hezbollah went into effect on June 20. Lebanon's Health Ministry and state news agency said one of the airstrikes targeted a home on the edge of the village of Ansar killed seven people, including three children, and wounded two. The second, on the village of Deir al-Zahrani, killed four and wounded 17. — AFP

Belgium Wildfire Burns at least 1,600 Hectares

One of Belgium's biggest-ever fires continues to burn, authorities yet to bring it under control

AFP

Belgium: Belgian firefighters backed by water bombers and helicopters were battling a rapidly spreading wildfire on Saturday at a natural park near the German border that ravaged at least 16 square kilometres (six square miles) in 24 hours. Reinforcements have been called in from across the country to help tackle the blaze at the Hautes Fagnes park, in the country's far east, with aerial support coming in from European partners under the EU's civil protection mechanism. The blaze, already one of the largest in Belgium's history, remains uncontrolled according to Nicolas Yernaux, a spokesperson for the re-



A French aircraft douses retarding liquid over trees during a wildfire in a forest near Lugion, southwestern France on Saturday. — AFP

gional authorities in Wallonia said. The nearby village of Sourbrodt, with about 500 residents, was under threat of evacuation after the fire, which broke out on Friday, ballooning in size overnight. "It is under consideration because of the smoke, but no final decision

has been taken yet," Yernaux said. "There is a risk that the fire could reach homes, but we are deploying all available resources to protect them," he added. The municipal Facebook page advised residents to prepare for a possible evacuation—packing es-

sential belongings, keeping doors and windows closed because of smoke, and remaining alert to official updates. In Eupen, a municipality close to the fire, the sky was gradually turning yellow, with columns of smoke visible in the distance, according to a journalist at the scene. "The situation is complicated and highly dependent on aerial resources," Yernaux said. Operations were being made harder by the fens' terrain—a patchwork of heath, peat bogs and raised wooden boardwalks. Firefighters had "pulled back to the edge of the forest and allowed parts of the heathland to burn because the area is very difficult to access," Yernaux said.

Taking Calculated Risks

From Page 1

Succession is often planned around a known retirement date rather than an unexpected exit. A successful incumbent can also wield considerable influence, making it difficult for boards to have an active conversation about who could eventually replace them. K Sudarshan, managing director of executive search firm EMA Partners India, said some succession exercises can go awry because certain leaders do not proactively facilitate them, creating a situation of "indispensability". "Boards have to ensure that CEOs are 'walking the talk' on succession," he said. A planned overlap between outgoing and incoming leaders can make a transition smoother, but such handovers are relatively rare. When a board has to appoint someone quickly, the choice becomes a calculated risk. "Any new leadership appointment is a 'leap of faith' decision," Sudarshan said. Internal candidates are generally the safer option because they understand the organisation and its culture. But when the internal bench is thin, companies have little choice but to look outside. Large Indian conglomerates have an advantage in this regard: depth. "By the very size of these groups there is always good talent available either within the specific company or other companies within the group," Deloitte's Ghose

said. Promoters and founders have also traditionally kept a close eye on talent. Yet size does not automatically make succession easier. In a group as complex as Tata, the next leader has to navigate businesses across sectors and geographies while balancing commercial objectives with the wider responsibilities of the group. "Succession is a process like a relay race," said Kavi Ramachandran, professor and member of the Supervisory Council, Thomas Schmidheiny Centre for Family Enterprise at the Indian School of Business. It involves assessing emerging scenarios, identifying the right candidate for the next lap, preparing for a brief overlap and ensuring a smooth handover of the baton. "This is very challenging in a group such as Tatas that is a huge conglomerate and is driven by both commercial and non-commercial goals," Ramachandran said. With the operating environment increasingly turbulent, finding someone who can step in at short notice and "hit the ground running" is particularly difficult. Family-controlled businesses face an additional layer of complexity, with family dynamics and multiple potential successors sometimes complicating decisions. Strong governance is needed to ensure individual preferences do not override the organisation's interests, Ramachandran said.

Opportunity for Paradigm Shift

From Page 1

Match Group, which operates Tinder, Hinge and OkCupid, also reported consecutive declines in paying users over the past two years. Both companies have increasingly turned to product changes and AI features to improve engagement. Back home, India's dating market has struggled to produce any breakout players. Aisle was acquired by Info Edge in 2022 and now largely focuses on its language-specific regional apps, while TrulyMadly, which launched in 2013, has shifted to catering to tier-2 cities and beyond and continues to incur losses as of FY25, according to Tracxn. "The product paradigm has not changed for 30 years. It's a

public bazaar, where people scroll endlessly, and that's not working. It's led to mental health issues, safety, security, and privacy issues, multiple scams, and it's just an inefficient way," said Varun Sud, co-founder of Juleo, which used AI to match users and facilitate in-person meetings. "AI presents the opportunity of changing the paradigm by replicating a human matchmaker," he added. Juleo, founded in 2023, however, shut down operations in February after failing to raise funding. Its investors included the founders of companies such as Livspace, Cred, Acko and Groww. Meanwhile, Elevation-backed Schmooze launched an AI-powered voice matchmaker, Riya, in April. Wavelength's Sarode said

about 40% of men on the platform are now getting matches, compared with less than 1% on mainstream dating apps.

MONETISING PLANS

As dating apps become more intentional, startups are also rethinking their economics. Wavelength plans to charge for successful introductions and is considering match packs priced at about ₹250 each initially. Knot.dating is positioning itself as a premium service, with subscriptions ranging from ₹50,000 to ₹5 lakh. For investors, the bet is that AI can turn online dating from an engagement business into an outcome business, while drastically reducing the cost of personalised matchmaking.

form, modernised training and enhanced capabilities to address evolving security needs. Modi said five new nuclear reactors are likely to be operational within 6-7 years as the country moves towards the target of 100 GW nuclear energy capacity by 2047. The PM appreciated the changing scale of India's ambitions that include 50 companies are in the Fortune 500 list, an Indian bank is among the top global banks, an Indian pharma company among the world's top five, an Indian law or rating agency achieving global leadership, an Indian consulting or accounting firm joining the ranks of the world's top firms, and an Indian tech firm among the world's top companies.

7.7 Magnitude Quake Strikes Indonesia, Killing at Least 47

Tsunami warning lifted after no major sea-level changes were detected: Officials

AP

Maumere: A powerful magnitude 7.7 earthquake struck off the coast of Indonesia early Saturday, killing at least 47 people, collapsing buildings and causing panic in a region prone to deadly quakes. Authorities said dozens more residents were injured and warned that the death toll would almost certainly rise.

Authorities issued a tsunami warning and urged coastal residents to move to higher ground, but later lifted the warning when Indonesia's meteorological agency said monitoring showed no significant sea-level changes that posed a threat to coastal communities. Some smaller tsunamis were reported. The US Geological Survey said the quake hit eastern Indonesia's Flores region at a depth of 10 kilometres (6 miles) at 5:58 a.m. local time. Its epicenter was 68 km (42 miles) north-northwest of the city of Ende in East Nusa Tenggara province. The meteorological agency said the quake was followed by at least 235 aftershocks, with the largest recorded at magnitude 6.2. The agency's sea-level monitoring stations acknowledged some small tsunamis reached coastal villages in Manggarai and East Manggarai regencies. Videos obtained by The As-

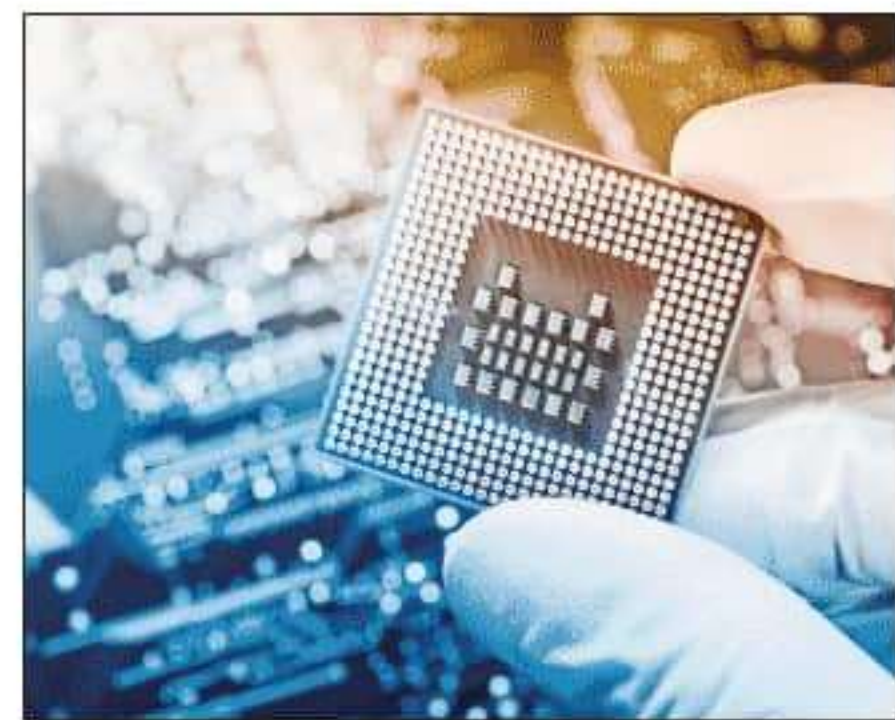


sociated Press showed the coastal village of Riung in Ngada regency blanketed in mud and debris after what the agency described as a 1.61-meter (5.3 feet) tsunami. Fishing boats were stranded ashore, infrastructure damaged, and homes surrounded by sediment left by receding waters. Waves measuring 0.94 meters (3.1 feet) were observed in Maurole, Ende Regency. Tsunami waves exceeding 0.5 meters (1.6 feet) were detected in Bulukumba, South Sulawesi, and Sape in Bima Regency. A strong, land-based earthquake of 6.9 magnitude hit North Sumatra province in western Indonesia on Saturday afternoon, according to the USGS. It struck 172.5 kilometres (107 miles) beneath the earth's surface, meaning it was too deep to cause significant damage or casualties, Indonesian authorities said.

'A Trusted Hub'

From Page 1

The prime minister warned that voices in support of globalisation have become rare and countries have started weaponising critical resources, including technology and chips. He reiterated his call for building the entire semiconductor manufacturing ecosystem, expanding the production basket to include both small components and large-scale products. "The entire value chain should be ours and we should move ahead with it," he said. "From design to manufacturing, India must emerge as a trusted hub in the global supply chain." During his In-



dependence Day speech, Modi also announced nationwide skilling of 10 million youth in artificial intelligence (AI) over the next one year. The initiative would help equip youth with the capability to lead in the world of AI, he said.

ET THE ECONOMIC TIMES

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Cleanser, moisturiser and sunscreen were once the only skincare products we needed to know. Today, the industry has its own language, with ingredients, treatments and buzzwords becoming part of everyday conversations. Here's a look at what they really mean.

A

AHAS
You no longer reach for the gunky face scrubs thanks to alpha hydroxy acids or AHAs. These chemical exfoliants clear away dead skin cells for brighter skin. Glycolic and lactic acids are the stars of the AHA world.

Azelaic acid
The quiet achiever of skincare. It tackles acne, redness and pigmentation in one go. This isn't an exfoliating acid and is well-tolerated by sensitive skin.

B

Barrier repair
Good skin begins with a healthy barrier. It keeps the moisture in and the irritants out.

BHAs
Beta-hydroxy-acids, or BHAs, cut through excess oil, clear clogged pores and help reduce blackheads and breakouts. Salicylic acid is the best-known BHA.

C

Ceramides
The cement that holds your skin cells together. Ceramides are lipids that lock in moisture, protect against environmental damage and reduce irritation.

D

Double cleansing
The two-step ritual has become the gold standard for removing sunscreen, makeup and pollution.

Healthy Barrier Over Hype

Social media may have made skincare more accessible, but it has also created a generation of self-taught skin experts. According to dermatologist Dr Geeta M Fazalbhoy, founder of Skin & You Clinic, "Healthy skin isn't achieved by following trends. It requires an understanding of your skin type, concerns and medical history."

A growing concern, says Fazalbhoy, is the "overuse of active ingredients, and excessive product layering, often called 'skin cycling' without proper understanding or even 'cosmeticorexia', an unhealthy obsession with using multiple skincare products".

"Many people combine retinoids, exfoliating acids, vitamin C, benzoyl peroxide and other actives without understanding their interactions. A well-designed routine with a few scientifically proven ingredients is far more effective than a complicated 10-step regimen. Healthy skin begins with preserving the skin barrier," she explains.

Looking ahead, Fazalbhoy believes regenerative treatments and personalised skincare routines "represent the future of dermatology". "Regenerative dermatology," she says, "focuses on stimulating the skin's natural repair

E

Exosomes
Tiny in size, big in promise. These microscopic messengers carry signals between cells and are attracting attention for their potential role in skin regeneration.

F

Face basting
A viral trend that requires coating the skin with a thick moisturiser or petroleum jelly overnight to help repair a damaged barrier.

G

Glutathione
The latest buzzword for brighter, more even-toned skin. Naturally produced by the body, glutathione helps protect cells from oxidative stress.

Glass skin
Coined in Korea, it refers to smooth and radiant skin that barely needs makeup.

H

Hyaluronic acid
Not an exfoliator. Hyaluronic acid is a humectant that draws moisture into the skin, leaving it smoother and more hydrated.

I

Ice rollers
Probably the coolest thing in your daily skincare. Ice rollers help depuff, cool irritated skin and temporarily tighten the appearance of pores.

J

Jojoba oil
The oil that even oily skin loves. Non-comedogenic and lightweight, jojoba oil closely resembles the skin's natural sebum, making it suitable for all skin types.

K

Kojic acid
Kojic acid is the comeback kid. It helps slow melanin production, making it a favourite for tackling pigmentation and post-acne marks.

L

LED light therapy
Red for collagen, blue for acne. LED light therapy uses different wavelengths to target different skin concerns.

M

Microbiome
Billions of beneficial microbes live on your face, and a new generation of skincare is designed to nourish them.

Microneedling
Microneedling creates tiny, controlled punctures in the skin to improve scars and trigger collagen production. Best performed in clinics, though at-home devices are available.

N

Niacinamide
Once unknown, now in every product you own. Niacinamide brightens skin, calms inflammation, strengthens the barrier and reduces excess oil.

O

Occlusives
Think of this as a cling film for your skincare. Occlusives lock in moisture, keeping your skin soft, smooth and protected.

P

PDRN
Derived from 'salmon DNA', PDRN (polydeoxyribonucleotide) is one of skincare's biggest obsessions and is being studied for its potential to repair damaged skin and improve hydration and elasticity.

Beauty and the Brief

If PDRN looks like a typo and exosomes sound like science fiction, Divya Verma gives you a cheat sheet to the language of modern skincare

divya.verma@timesofindia.com

Beyond the Hero Ingredient



The skincare industry may have turned ingredients into the heroes, but cosmetic chemist and CEO at Capsum KKT, Krupa Koestline, believes they are "only part of the story". "A formula is a system: The concentration and stability of the active, its delivery to the skin, the supporting ingredients, the pH, the packaging and whether people can tolerate and enjoy using it consistently all affect performance," she says. A well-formulated product, she adds, begins with a genuine skin need, not a trend. Consumers should look beyond hero ingredient claims and choose brands that are transparent about testing, ingredient function and how a product is designed to work. Looking ahead, Koestline is excited by the convergence of biotechnology, botanical science and smarter

delivery systems. She points to precision farming, which could make botanical ingredients more reliable and traceable, and ectoin, which helps support skin under stress.

Koestline also sees promise in mRNA and advanced delivery technologies that could influence skin biology in more targeted ways. "An ingredient is only as good as the system that keeps it stable and delivers it where it needs to go," she says.

Her biggest piece of advice? "Skincare does not need to be so serious. Yes, formulation matters... but if you keep your skin moisturised, protect it from the sun and use products that agree with your skin, you will be fine." She adds, "Skincare should support your skin and make you feel good; it should not become another source of stress."

V

Vitamin C
The real glow-getter that hates sunlight. Vitamin C can help even out your skin and boost radiance.

X

Xeomin
The injectable called the 'naked Botox'. Xeomin is a botulinum toxin injectable that's attracting attention for its purified formulation.

Y

Yellow peel
Dermatologist-administered chemical peel designed to brighten skin, improve texture and fade pigmentation.

W

Waterless beauty
Waterless beauty replaces traditional water-based formulas with concentrated ingredients, reducing water use while delivering more potent skincare.

Z

Zombie cells
Senescent or 'zombie cells' are ageing cells that stop functioning but refuse to die, contributing to inflammation and skin ageing. Scientists are exploring ways to target them as part of longevity research.

The Great Skin Reset



The biggest change in skincare isn't what's available on the shelves; it's the modern consumers. Celebrity dermatologist Dr Bindu Shalekar, founder of Skin Smart Solutions, says today there are more informed questions about prevention, skin barrier health and sun protection.

"Earlier, the focus was largely on anti-ageing and finding quick fixes for wrinkles or pigmentation. Today, more people understand that a healthy barrier is the foundation of beautiful skin," she says.

Shalekar warns consumers not to confuse social media popularity with scientific evidence. "Products that promise 'instant results', 'permanent pore reduction', or 'miracle cures' should be

viewed with caution. A product should have scientific backing, not just viral popularity. When in doubt, consult a dermatologist instead of relying solely on influencer recommendations," she says.

Shalekar believes the future lies in personalised, science-led skincare rather than one-size-fits-all routines. Innovations such as microbiome-friendly skincare, biomimetic peptides, AI-assisted skin analysis and exosome research are shaping the next generation of treatments.

"The future of skincare," she says, "will be smarter, more personalised and backed by stronger scientific evidence," she says.

Three Page-Turners for Rainy Evenings

THE SUMMER WE LIED by Rebecca Hardy

Eighteen years ago, Shawn Weston was convicted of the murder of a mother and child. A determined journalist has always thought there is more to the story. As the conviction is on the verge of being overturned and new DNA evidence points to a new suspect, he tracks down two witnesses who were teenagers at the time.

The story jumps between the narratives of Alex, Rachel and Jonathan — the three friends involved, as their adult selves pick apart what really happened on that fateful day. Secrets are unveiled and stories that were previously unknown to the investigation are shared.

Featuring police corruption, sexual abuse, small town conspiracies and broken friendships, it is a dark story full of intrigue.

THE KILL SWITCH by Robert Peston

Political journalists Gil Peck and his partner Jess secure an interview with the British prime minister for their podcast, promising an insight into the premier's views on the growing influence of AI as well as anecdotes on their times together as friends.

But instead of talking politics,

the journalists have an unexpected scoop on their hands when the prime minister becomes unwell, collapses mid-interview, and later dies.

The race to find out what happened turns into a murder hunt. The journalists discover the PM had blocked a contract for a major tech company to manage public sector systems, which they suspect led to her assassination. But the deeper they delve, the more danger they face, with devastating consequences.

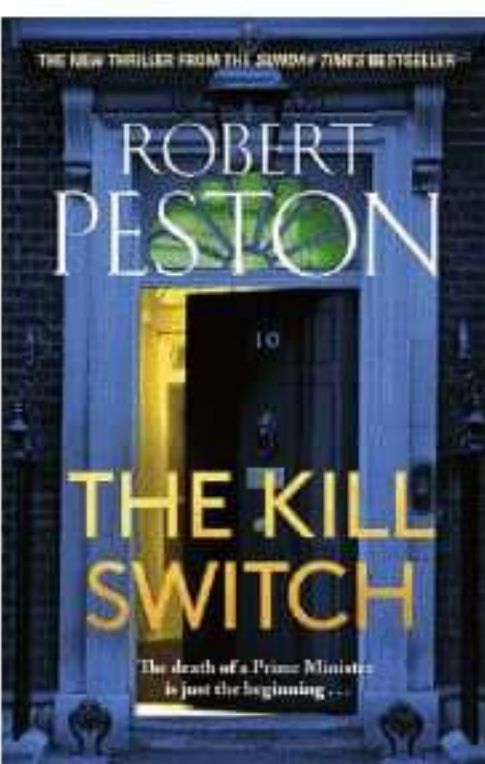
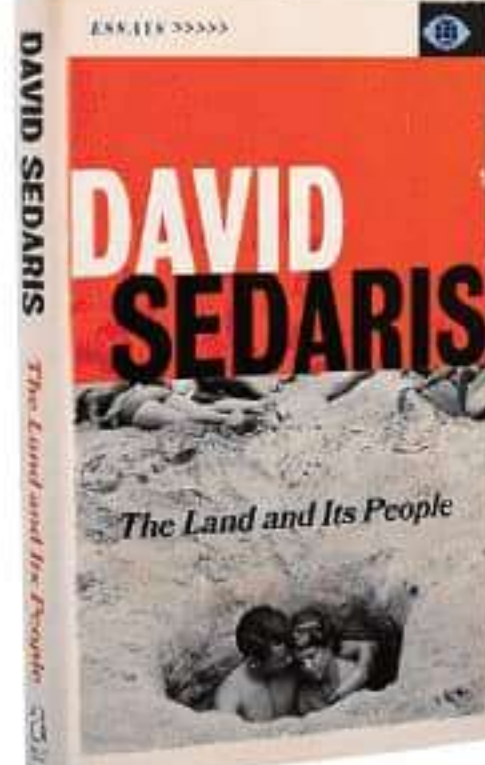
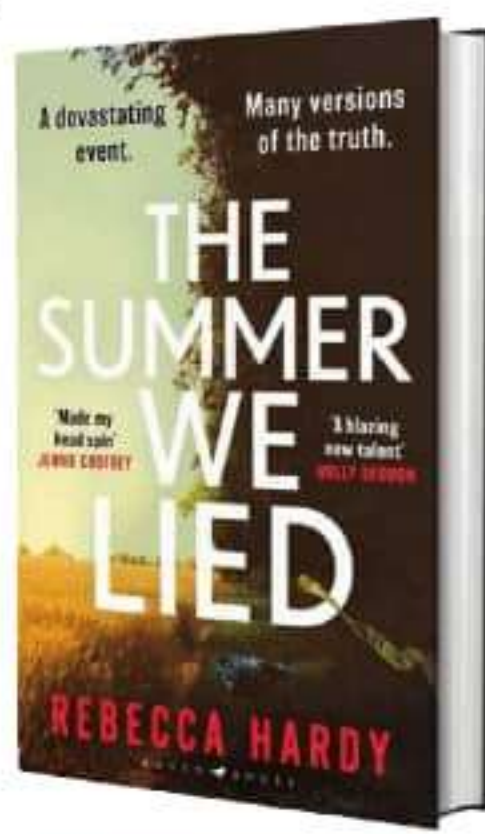
THE LAND AND ITS PEOPLE by David Sedaris

As the author of multiple books — mostly collections of personal essays — you would be forgiven for thinking American humorist David Sedaris does not have much left to say. But his insights are as razor sharp as ever.

In his latest offering, Sedaris gives us 28 chapters from his life, describing moments like making his boyfriend cook Christmas dinner after hip-replacement surgery, meeting the Pope and buying a priest's cassock, getting bitten by a dog and learning German via a moody AI teenager on Duolingo.

It feels like a sardonic uncle sitting around the table regaling the rest of the family with stories of his life and travels.

— Daily Mirror



Rome's New Tourist Trap: The Pasta-Making Nonna

Italian restaurants are advertising the freshness of their product by strategically placing working women by their windows



Natalie B Compton

Along the painted alleyways of Trastevere, a touristy neighbourhood on the banks of the Tiber River in Rome, are restaurants that prominently feature pasta makers. It's a shtick that's spreading across the city — popping up near ancient ruins and charming piazzas. It's reminiscent of the city's other hospitality trends, like pasta served out of giant cheese wheels and sauté pans.

Only this one feeds off the appreciation for the 'Italian nonna', whose generational kitchen wisdom and folksy charm won over the internet. This one also strategically places the women near the windows — they're meant to entice customers walking past.

CHASING AUTHENTICITY

One afternoon, Sophie Minchilli saw a long line snaking outside a restaurant. Inside, at a table overlooking the front window, a woman rolled strands of pasta. "It's literally like a zoo," said Minchilli.

Minchilli has watched the pasta window trend spread. She sees their presence as a scourge.

Minchilli has one test to tell if a place is authentic or a tourist trap: Does it stay open in the afternoons? A truly traditional place, she said, will close in the afternoon to give staff a break, but one that caters to tourists will even serve up pasta at 3pm.

QUESTION OF FRESHNESS

Another issue is the pasta itself. In Italy, pasta has its own established ways; its shape, ingredients and production vary by region. Roman cuisine, for instance, is rooted in dry pasta. Of the capital's four iconic pastas — carbonara, gricia, amatriciana and cacio e pepe — only the latter is typically made fresh.

A restaurant advertising fresh pasta as traditional Roman cuisine is a red flag, says author Katie Parla. Making the pasta production visible to customers' Even redder: "They are providing staged content for the people," said Parla.

— The Washington Post

Akur-chi-bhaji and the Ancient Mysteries of Ferns

FOOD FABLES



VIKRAM DOCTOR

Boundary walls in Goa are usually made of local laterite. This is iron-rich compacted earth that hardens on exposure to air, but still contains lots of crevices. When the monsoons arrive, these soak up rain and sprout delicate little plants, like maidenhair ferns. By August, most walls are shaggy green.

Ferns are particularly suited for this because they don't produce

seeds, but spores, which are expelled from the fronds as the plant matures. Most drift away, but some settle into the walls, lying dormant till the rains return. For centuries, the way ferns reproduced was a mystery, since the leaves grew so easily and everywhere, yet with no visible flowers or fruit. People believed ferns' 'invisible seeds' had magical powers. "We have the receipt of fern seed: We walk invisible" boasts a criminal character in Shakespeare's play Henry IV.

Ferns still hold real mysteries. In the 1950s, CA Ninan, a famous pteridologist (fern botanist), who passed away last year, discovered that Ophioglossum reticulatum, a fern found in Palakkad district, whose snaking leaf gave it the name of adder's tongue fern, possessed around 1,400 chromosomes. "To put this number into perspective, humans have 46 chromosomes (in 23



PIC: GETTY IMAGES

pairs), corn has 20, spinach has 12, mosquitoes have six... no other known organism on this planet has anywhere close to these many chromosomes," write Fay-Wei Li and Jacob S Suissa in Ferns: Lessons in Survival from the World's Most Adaptable Plants.

The adder's tongue is extreme, but ferns often have abundant chromosomes, and it isn't clear why. It may be their antiquity. Ferns were among the first successful land plants, emerging in the middle-Devonian period, 390 million years ago, and over time, could have just accumulated chromosomes. Most probably serve no purpose, but some might enable the extreme adaptability of ferns, which grow everywhere from the tropics to near Arctic conditions. They are found in forests and jungles, lakes and deserts and one salt-tolerant

species survives on coastal rocks.

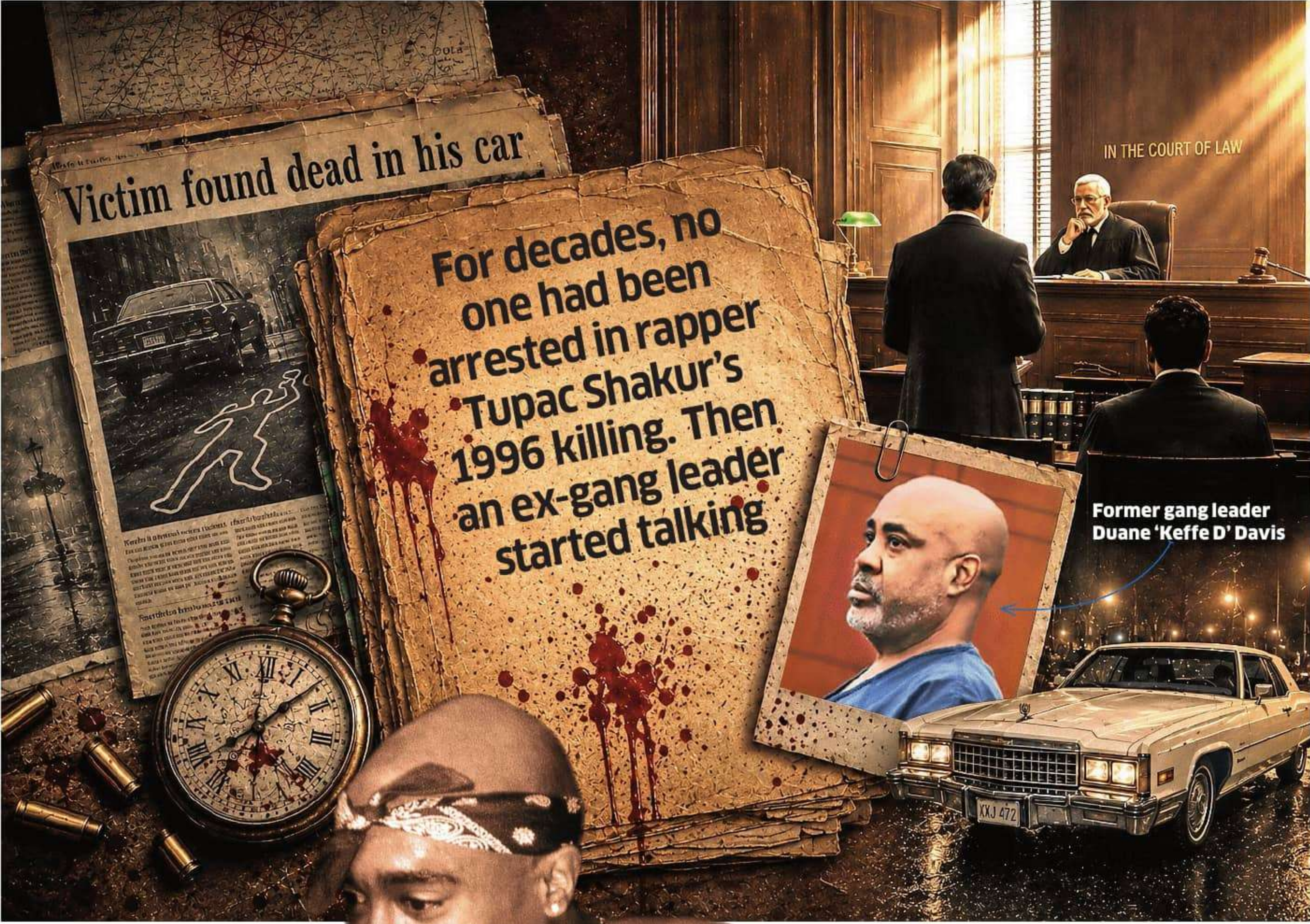
We rarely think of ferns as food, but many are edible. They tend to have bitter or mildly vegetal tastes and some contain potentially toxic compounds that must be removed through cooking. Many plants that we eat today were like this in their original wild forms, and it is taken centuries of selective breeding to give them their current form. Gardeners have figured out how to propagate ferns by dividing plants or growing them from rhizomes, but the absence of fruits and seeds could have been why early farmers never selectively bred ferns.

In Japan, a starch from fern rhizomes is used to make a sweet called warabimochi. Other ferns have rhizomes that taste sweet themselves, with a herbal taste like liquorice. The most commonly consumed parts of ferns are the tender young shoots that unfurl from a tight spiral, giving them the look of the curved top of a violin's handle. This is why these shoots are called fiddleheads, and while many

recipes specify fiddlehead ferns, there is no specific fern of that name. Fiddlehead is a general term for fern shoots and their elegant spirals are perhaps the most appealing reason to cook them.

They are a popular foraged vegetable in the hills, like Uttarakhand, where they are called lingda and are often pickled. Rohini Rana, in Memories on a Platter, recalls how they are loved in Nepal and suggests frying them in a tempura batter. Eastern India knows them as Assam's dhekia xaak or Bengal's dhecki shaag, and in Coorg they are a monsoon delicacy called thermé thoppu. The slightly more mature shoots of the golden mangrove fern are also harvested in the monsoon in Goa. They are strikingly attractive, with slender green stalks shading to red-gold. Akur-chi-bhaji, as it is called, can be tasty, especially when cooked with small mangrove shrimp. It reminds us why we should value ferns, an ancient lineage of plants that still hold mysteries for us today.

Unfinished Verse



PICS: AI GENERATED, AFP, GETTY IMAGES

Hannah Knowles

For almost three decades, the police said they couldn't solve the killing of rap icon Tupac Shakur. Then a former gang leader, Duane 'Keffe D' Davis, started talking — recounting the drive-by shooting in interviews and a memoir.

Now Davis will stand trial in a high-profile case that has captivated the public. Jury selection recently started in Las Vegas, not far from the intersection where Shakur was shot on September 7, 1996. The trial is expected to take several weeks.

Davis has pleaded not guilty to one count of murder and said he was in the car when a back-seat passenger opened fire on Shakur. His attorney, through a representative, declined to discuss the case. Authorities accuse him of orchestrating the killing, without alleging that he was the gunman. They say the trial might never have happened if not for Davis's own public comments.

LOST STAR

Shakur was at the height of his fame when he died at the age of 25, mourned as one of the most influential artists of the era. He had hit the top of the charts that year with songs like 'California Love'.

Speaking at Shakur's posthumous induction into the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame in 2017, rapper Snoop Dogg — a friend and collaborator — said that "while many remember him now as some kind of thugged-out superhero, Tupac knew he was only human and he represented through his music like no one before."

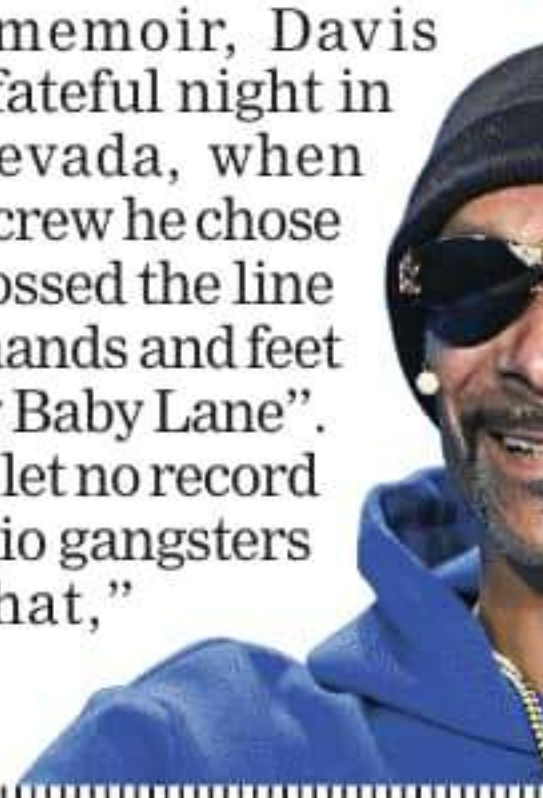
Here's what to know about the case and decades-old mystery.

Officials say the shooting arose from a rivalry between two Los Angeles-area gangs: Mob Piru and South Side Compton Crips. Shakur's record label, Death Row Records, was affiliated with Mob Piru, police have said, while Davis was "the leader and shot caller" of the Crips.

Members of both groups were in Las Vegas the day of the shooting to watch boxer Mike Tyson fight at the MGM Grand Garden Arena. After the event, police say, the Death Row Records entourage beat up Davis's nephew.

In his 2019 memoir, Davis recounts that "fateful night in Las Vegas, Nevada, when Tupac and the crew he chose to run with crossed the line and put their hands and feet on my nephew Baby Lane".

"We couldn't let no record company studio gangsters do us like that," Davis wrote.



Davis wrote that he set out to confront the Death Row Records group, adding that his entourage was prepared "a [in] case the diplomatic approach didn't work".

UNFINISHED CASE

Davis was riding in a white Cadillac with three other men, authorities say, when they found Shakur. Davis had earlier tossed a gun into the car's back seat, according to his book.

Shakur was in a black BMW driven by Marion 'Suge' Knight, a co-founder of Death Row Records. In Davis's telling, Shakur "made an erratic move" and "pulled out a strap" — slang for drawing a gun.

"[That's] when the fireworks started," Davis wrote. "One of my guys from the back seat grabbed the Glock and started bustin' back." Asked decades later in a documentary interview who shot Shakur, Davis declined to give a name while citing "the code of the streets".

Prosecutors will argue at trial that Davis was the ringleader in Shakur's killing. At a news conference announcing charges against Davis in 2023, Clark County district attorney Steve Wolfson said that "if you help somebody commit a crime, you can be equally as guilty".

When law enforcement announced Davis's arrest, they said detectives learned many of the details of what happened. But they never had enough evidence to bring a case, officials said.

Then, in 2018, Davis was featured in a documentary series, Death Row Chronicles, recounting the events leading up to Shakur's death.

The three other people allegedly in the Cadillac with Davis — Deandrea 'Freaky' Smith, Davis's nephew Orlando 'Baby Lane' Anderson and driver Terry 'Bubble Up' Brown — have all died.

In 2019, Davis published his memoir, Compton Street Legend.

LONG ROAD

Davis's defence has tried to block prosecutors from using some of his comments in court — including from the book, which defence attorney Michael Sanft noted was written with a co-author and argued was fictionalised "to sell a product". But Judge Carli Kierny of the Eighth Judicial District Court rejected that argument, noting that Davis has described the book as the truth.

In court documents, prosecutors have listed more than 200 potential witnesses, with people as varied as investigators and the former head of security for Death Row Records. They said they could also call members of Shakur's family, such as his sister Sekiywa Shakur and stepbrother Maurice 'Mopreme' Shakur, a former member of the hip-hop group ThugLife.

The defence has notified the court that they might call an expert on false confessions and "coercive interrogation techniques", among many others. Davis's attorney tried to block prosecutors from drawing on an interview police recorded with Davis in 2008, saying it was "involuntary".

"I sang because they promised I would not be prosecuted," Davis wrote in his memoir.

But the judge sided with prosecutors and allowed use of the interview at trial.

— The Washington Post

The Comic Who Lives In a Castle

Alan Carr says people can't quite believe that he really lives in a Scottish castle now.

The comedian, 50, bought Aytoun Castle in the Scottish Borders this year and is making a documentary series about the experience, called Castle Man.

But he says: "Everyone thinks it's a gimmick — that's the problem — but I'm living there!" He adds of early media reports on his move, "They said it would become a hotel with a leisure centre and spa, when it's actually my permanent home."

"Now I've been sent lots of CVs from life guards and someone even gifted me a Jacuzzi hot tub. But it's grade-A listed so I've had to send it back!" But Carr admits it is such a



Aytoun Castle



The castle is one of Scotland's "most important historic



There is plenty of room for a book collection

PICS: KNIGHT FRANK, GETTY IMAGES

huge change from his earlier life, he can hardly get his head around it.

DREAM COME TRUE

The comic, who grew up on an estate in the suburbs of Northampton, says of his new 3.2-million pounds baronial mansion:

"It's so funny being in there, coming down the stairs and whatnot. Sometimes I have to pinch myself."

Though he has no dastardly leisure centre ideas for his castle, Carr does have plans.

The residence is to be used for a range of community activities, while a section of the sprawling 160-acre grounds is being turned into a glamping site for a few weeks.

So, while the 17 bedrooms and nine bathrooms are all for Carr, the public

will be able to enjoy nights in the castle's parkland under canvas.

Paying 140-160 pounds a night, guests will stay in a luxury bell tent sleeping up to four, and can also enjoy sauna and cold water sessions plus guided movement classes.

PERFECT ESCAPE

Carr says of his community plans: "Comedy at the castle, carol singing, Burns Night, just really fun things."

"I think people get a bit funny about me wanting to live in a castle, but when they see what I'm going to do with it... it's not just me lying on a chaise longue with a tiny bell."

Part of the appeal of his new home is all the different eras hidden within its walls.

He explains: "During the war it was turned into a little school so there's pockets of it that are very 1950s." And he says it has been the perfect way to escape the heatwaves.

— Daily Mirror

VITALS
Australia on Ropes as Bangladesh Dominate Day 3
Darwin: Australia all-rounder Cameron Green and wicketkeeper Alex Carey were left with an improbable rescue mission on Saturday as Bangladesh moved within six wickets of an upset for the ages on day three of the first Test. Australia, the world's top-ranked Test nation, were in trouble at 161 for 4 at stumps, still 67 runs in arrears after Bangladesh's underrated batsmen put 426 on the board. A victory scenario that appeared unthinkable days ago burst into view after tea, when Australia's No. 4 Steve Smith spooned a caught-and-bowled to all-rounder Mehidy Hasan Miraz to be out for 44. The departure of Australia's time-honoured saviour left the hosts in trouble at 122 for four and had Bangladesh players mobbing and roaring in triumph on the Marrara Oval pitch. **Reuters**

Hungry Arsenal Target Community Shield
London: Arsenal are eager to get their hands on the first trophy of the new season when they face Manchester City in this weekend's Community Shield, with manager Mikel Arteta saying on Friday that his squad have returned refreshed and highly motivated. Sunday's traditional curtain-raiser will see Premier League champions Arsenal take on FA Cup winners City in Cardiff. Arsenal, who lost last season's Champions League final to Paris St Germain on penalties, aim to begin the campaign on a positive note after ending a 22-year wait for the Premier League title. "The best version of Arsenal has to be on Sunday. That's the intention. The best performance, the best way to start the season [is] by lifting the first trophy. That's the way we've prepared for the season. On day one, be at our maximum level," Arteta told reporters. **Reuters**

WATCHOUT! Tonight
COMMUNITY SHIELD
Arsenal v Manchester City 7:30am (Sony Sports Network)



PSG sign Spain's World Cup hero Torres from Barcelona
Paris: Paris St Germain have signed Spain's World Cup final match-winning forward Ferran Torres from Barcelona on a contract until 2031, the two clubs announced on Saturday. Financial details were not disclosed, but media reports said PSG paid €50 million (\$57.83 million) for the 26-year-old. "I am happy, of course. I think we are improving our team," PSG head coach Luis Enrique told a press conference Saturday. The forward scored 21 goals and provided three assists in 49 appearances across all competitions for Barca in their last campaign as the club retained their LaLiga title. Torres joined Barcelona in 2022 after a brief spell at Premier League side Manchester City. **Reuters**

Liverpool Deal With Bezos Raises Stakes in US Battle for Premier League Power
Liverpool's decision to sell a minority stake to a consortium of financial heavy hitters including Amazon founder Jeff Bezos is the latest move in the battle for supremacy between the American owners in the Premier League. Just four months after Arsenal won the Premier League under the ownership of US billionaire Stan Kroenke, Liverpool's hierarchy have opted for outside investment in a bid to regain the crown. Armed with the cash generated by selling around a third of the club to Bezos and company, Liverpool will seek to dethrone Arsenal and claim a record 21st English title. Joining the fight for Premier League bragging rights are Manchester United, majority-owned by US family the Glazers and Chelsea, whose ownership group is headed by American Todd Boehly. Aston Villa, last season's Europa League winners, are among six other Premier League clubs in which Americans hold ownership stakes. The US-inspired Premier League arms race has led to a substantial spike in the valuations of England's top clubs, giving their owners a handsome return on their initial investment. **AFP**

Padikkal Rises To the Occasion

Drafted in after Sudharsan's injury, Devdutt repays the faith with a maiden century that could solve India's No. 3 puzzle



Anand Vasu REGARDLESS

If the Indian think tank needed any proof that their best chance of making it to the final of the World Test Championship was to play on good pitches at home, it was provided in Galle. On a surface that was good for batting — even if the odd ball gripped and there was a hint of uneven bounce that could play a part later — the top order delivered the most assured batting performance they have had in some time.

The clamour to mop up as many points as possible in home series has meant that India have played on dry, underprepared surfaces too often, exposing their batsmen. None of the top order, who are anyway short of experience in playing on rank turners because they hardly get such surfaces in domestic cricket, has been able to build any rhythm or confidence.

When Shubman Gill won the toss, a crucial one, not long after he had unfurled the tricolour to mark Independence Day, there would have been a collective sigh of relief in the dressing room.

Yashasvi Jaiswal and KL Rahul then showed why they are such a good pairing at the top of the order. Jaiswal is always on the hunt to score quickly and plays his shots while Rahul is rarely fussed by what is happening around him. That the combination is left-and-right-handed makes it tougher for the bowlers to settle on one line, and with the ball coming onto the bat nicely, there was good value for stroke play.

It was against the run of play that the first wicket fell when Rahul hit to mid-on and set off for a quick run. Jaiswal, who had slipped, regained composure only long enough to see his partner standing right beside him at the non-striker's end and a simple run out was completed.

At 48 for 1, Devdutt Padikkal, India's latest No. 3, had a chance to show what he was made of. There are few batting positions as pivotal as No. 3 in Test cricket, and India have not had a settled batsman there since Cheteshwar Pujara. At different times, Virat Kohli, Rahul, Karun Nair, Gill, Padikkal himself, Washington Sundar and Sai Sudharsan have been deployed at No. 3.

Had it not been for a toe injury to Sudharsan, Padikkal would not even have got a chance here. But once he was allowed in, Padikkal left nothing



DEVDUUTT PADIKKAL

to chance. Coming down the wicket to the spinner early on, Padikkal launched one long ball straight towards the fort, and you sensed that he was in flow.

Padikkal has always been easy on the eye, but there was the lingering doubt that his languid manner and long levers — not too many Indian top-order batsmen are 6'3" tall — made him look better than he actually was. But he has a wide range of shots, and when he uses them smart-

ly, as he did on the day, the bowlers are in for a real headache.

It has been 19 Tests and 35 innings since an Indian No. 3 scored a hundred, with Gill the last to reach the milestone in Chennai against Bangladesh in 2024. Padikkal's unbeaten 131 put India well in control of the game even after an hour and 40 minutes, and 17 overs were lost to two rain interruptions.

Padikkal did not even know whether he would get a game in this series,

The way Devdutt was preparing and I saw it at the NCA (BCCI CoE), he was working on his back foot game. We try that when we expect a turn from a pitch. We also tried to work on step-out, sweep besides the back foot game. So, a lot of credit goes to him, the way he has prepared himself for the last couple of years

SITANSHU KOTAK
India's batting coach

We were consistent with our areas for the most part of the game. The spinners in particular created some opportunities but didn't have much luck. Credit to Padikkal in particular for the manner in which he batted. It was only his third Test and he looked solid

JORDAN GREGORY
Sri Lanka's fielding coach

but he had prepared consummately. Back at the Karnataka Institute of Cricket in Bangalore, Padikkal had sourced Kookaburra balls — which are in use in Sri Lanka — and worked with Naseeruddin Mohammed, his coach, against spinners of varying heights on tailor-made turning tracks. For eight consecutive days, he batted for three hours or more, and this paid off in the stylish 142 not out that Padikkal made in the warm-up match at Nondescripts Cricket Club in Colombo.

When the second day begins, India will know that their best option is to bat Sri Lanka out of this Test. Rahul, who retired hurt on 77 with cramps, struggling with pain in his hand and limping, will be keen to get back to the crease.

While there were suggestions that the pitch at Galle may be a difficult one to take 20 wickets on quickly enough, it will not be easy for Sri Lanka if India rack up something approaching 600, which will be the aim.

Forever and a day, India's best chance of winning, especially at home, has been batting big in the first innings. While winning the toss gains significance in this approach, there is definite merit to this conventional wisdom. And a team that has looked like it was struggling suddenly looks like the pieces are all falling in place.

BRIEF SCORES India 288 for 2 (Padikkal 131*, Rahul 77 retired hurt, Jaiswal 32, Pant 27*; Jayasuriya 1/77) vs Sri Lanka at Stumps on Day 1.

Worlds Apart

FROM ALSO-RANS TO MEDAL WINNERS
17 years on, the BWF World Badminton Championships returns to a different India



PV SINDHU



Garima Verma

Much has changed over these 17 years since BWF World Championships last travelled to India.

The 2009 hosts were a tiny presence on the global badminton map then. A previous generation's feats were far in the past, while a younger one was just heralding a new era for Indian badminton. A 19-year-old Saina Nehwal had just become the first Indian to win a BWF Super Series title. Also, China's domination on the game was absolute, led by the likes of Lin Dan, Chen Jin, Xie Xingfang, and more in every category. At the Hyderabad edition of the Championships, they pocketed 10 of the 20 medals and four of the five golds.

In 2026, with the capital hosting the tournament at a refurbished Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium, starting tomorrow till August 23, none of the countries enjoys that kind of command over the courts. And, India has long graduated from participation-happy to medal-winners. The 14 World Championships medals, including PV Sindhu's gold in 2019, three Olympic podium finishes, and three world top-ranks (Nehwal, Kidambi Srikanth, and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy-Chirag Shetty) prove the point.

China has not won the women's singles title since 2011. In the men's singles, the top seed and world No. 1, Shi Yuqi, might still be coming from China, but he is hardly an outright favourite. His path to the title will be anything but easy as the category is almost a minefield.

Shi has won only one tournament this year, while world No. 2 Kunlavut Vitidsarn, No. 3 Jonathan Christie, No. 4 Anders Antonsen, and No. 5 Christo Popov, sensational No. 7 Victor Lai are all entering the tournament with better results.

The defending champion Shi, in fact, starts his campaign against home boy Ayush Shetty, whom he beat to win his that lone title at the Badminton Asia Championships.

"If he wins that, it opens up the draw," said the Indian national head coach Pullela Gopichand of the matchup, words that indicated both Shetty's calibre and a probability of an upset adding another layer of excitement to the men's singles.

If Lakshya Sen, world No. 14 and 2022 edition bronze medalist, could persevere and outsmart Thailand's Vitidsarn, whom he might face in the pre-quarterfinals, the Indians would have played their part in the party.

Similar is the story in the men's doubles, except that India have serious podium expectations from world No. 5 and 2025 bronze-medallist duo of Satwik-Chirag. South Korean top guns Kim Won Ho and Seo Seung Jae no longer look as invincible as they did in 2025. The defending champions have their main nemesis in Indonesia's Fajar Alfian and Muhammad Shohibul, who ousted them at both Japan Open and China Open this year.

Satwik-Chirag's triumph over the Indonesian pair at the Singapore Open in May has been the highlight of their season so far, which has otherwise been marred by early exits and injuries.

"The quality of the top 20 is what the top 10 used to be," Scottish European champion Kirsty Gilmour summed up the sport's competitiveness and the hunger of its younger generation, in a recent BWF interview.

Yet, while the women's events have clear gold-medal favourites — South Korean top-seed An Se Young in singles, and China's top-ranked Liu Sheng Shu-Tan Ning in doubles — there is only one woman all eyes will be on. Sindhu, the five-time world championship medalist, is ranked No. 9 in the world and has struck form at just the right time, winning the Japan Open last month after beating defending world champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan.

The draw has been kind to her, too. Sindhu will not run into the likes of Young or Yamaguchi before the medal rounds. Chinese world No. 3 Wang Zhi Yi and No. 4 Chen Yufei have already cautioned everybody about the challenge Sindhu has been mounting.

Add to that an enviable record at an event which is second only to the Olympics for the sport, and a home turf, her rivals have much more to worry about than her celebrated smash.

WOMEN'S WORLD CUP WALL OF CHINA AWAITS INDIA IN OPENER

Amstelveen: A confident India face a stern opening test at the Women's FIH Hockey World Cup today when they take on Olympic silver medalists China in a Pool D match where there will be little room for error. Ninth-ranked India face second-ranked China in a contest that could set the tone for their campaign. With England and South Africa also in the pool and the tournament being played under a new format, India cannot afford a slow start. India's best World Cup finish came at the inaugural edition in 1974, when the team led by Ajinder Kaur finished fourth. Having featured in only eight of the previous 15 editions, they will be looking to improve on their ninth-place finish in 2022. Eleven members of the squad will be making their World Cup debuts, but India have plenty of players with experience of high-pressure international matches. **PTI**

LIVE on Star Sports & Hotstar, 4:30pm

Golf's Great Divide: Brilliant on Course, Bungling Off It

The majors produced four champions and a season of rare drama; off the course, leaders served up delay, division and dysfunction



Anand Datla

Golf in 2026 gave us a major championship season worthy of its cathedrals, then spent the rest of the year proving the men running the sport couldn't organise a two-car funeral.

FOUR DIFFERENT WINNERS, ZERO CORONATIONS

Start at Augusta, where Rory McIlroy achieved a feat of rare distinction: he defended a green jacket. McIlroy shot 12-under to become just the fourth man — after Jack Nicklaus, Nick Faldo and Tiger Woods — to win back-to-back Masters, a year removed from the career Grand Slam that ended his eleven-year purgatory. It was his sixth major, consolidating his place among the pantheon of greats.

Then the majors did something they almost never do: they refused to repeat themselves. Aaron Rai, known mostly for his two black golf gloves and a met-

ronomic short game, ran away with the PGA Championship at Aronimink, becoming the first English-born winner of that title in more than a century.

Wyndham Clark, who'd been booed and second-guessed since his last major in 2023, built a six-shot cushion at Shinnecock Hills, nearly coughed it up to Sam Burns down the stretch, then drained a 24-foot putt on 16 to close out a one-shot US Open win — his second. Scottie Scheffler, the sport's metro-nome, finished tied-fourth and saw his own Grand Slam bid expire in the Long Island wind.

The Open Championship provided the season's signature theater: Ryan Fox rolling in a ten-foot birdie on the 72nd hole at Royal Birkdale to steal the Claret Jug.

Four majors, four champions — McIlroy, Rai, Clark and Fox — the first wild horse race in years.

Scheffler's strokes-gained numbers (2.81 for the season) still topped the field, a reminder that the world No. 1 remains golf's most relentless ball-striker even when the trophies don't cooperate.

A ROLLBACK THAT KEEPS ROLLING BACK

Off the course, the golf ball rollback — meant to finally rein in a distance arms race that had reduced classic courses to pitch-and-putts — became a case study in institutional paralysis.

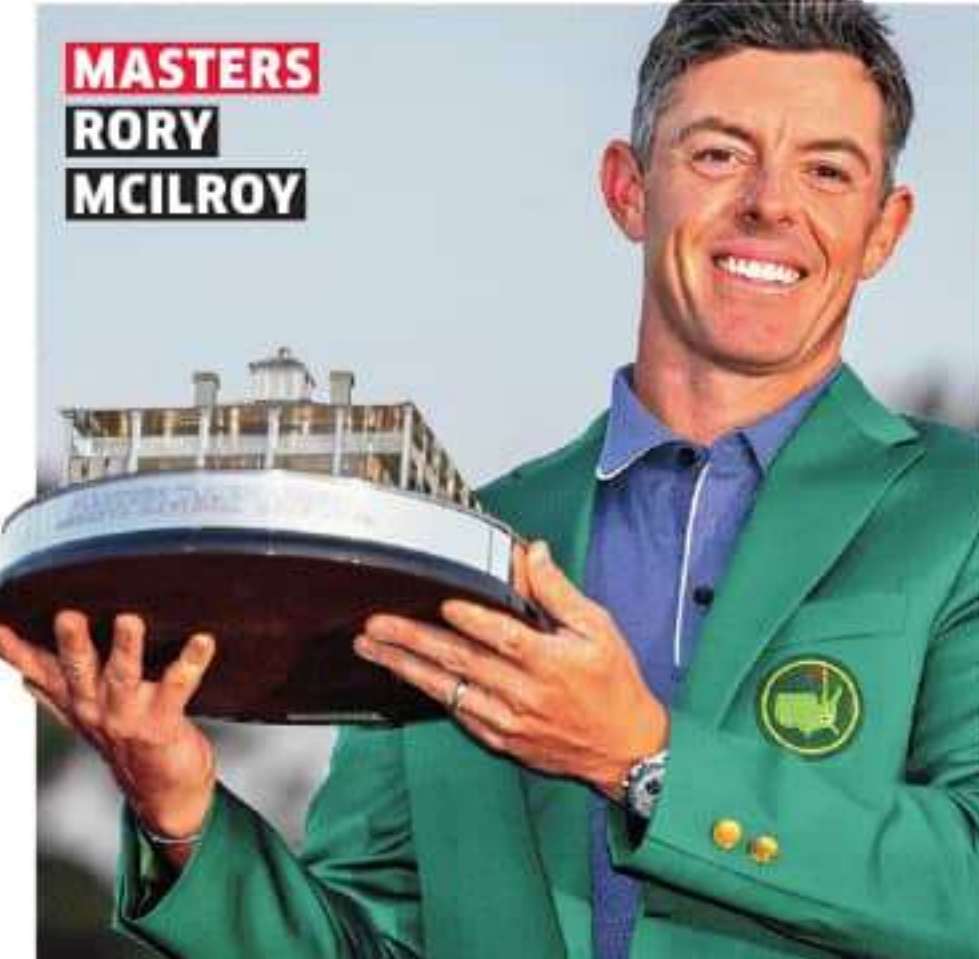
The United States Golf Association (USGA) and R&A — golf's rule-making bodies — had planned to implement new Overall Distance Standard testing for elite players in 2028 and everyone else by 2030, trimming 13 to 15 yards off tour pros' drives.

In June, on the eve of the US Open, the two governing bodies, flanked by the PGA Tour and DP World Tour, admitted the plan wasn't strong enough and pushed the entire rollout to a single date: January 2030.

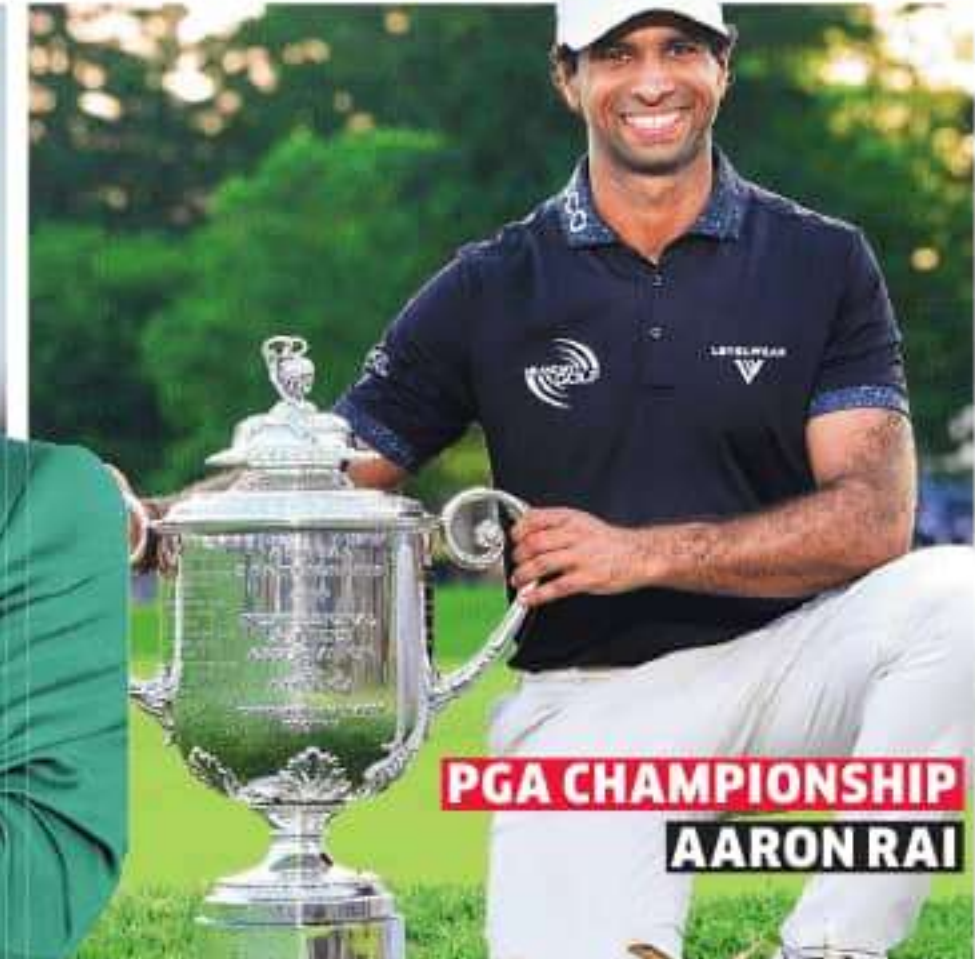
USGA chief Mike Whan signaled there will be no further extension, and bifurcation — letting pros play a different ball than weekend hackers, an idea the equipment industry has fought for a decade — is reportedly back on the table. Four years of study produced a delay, a reopened



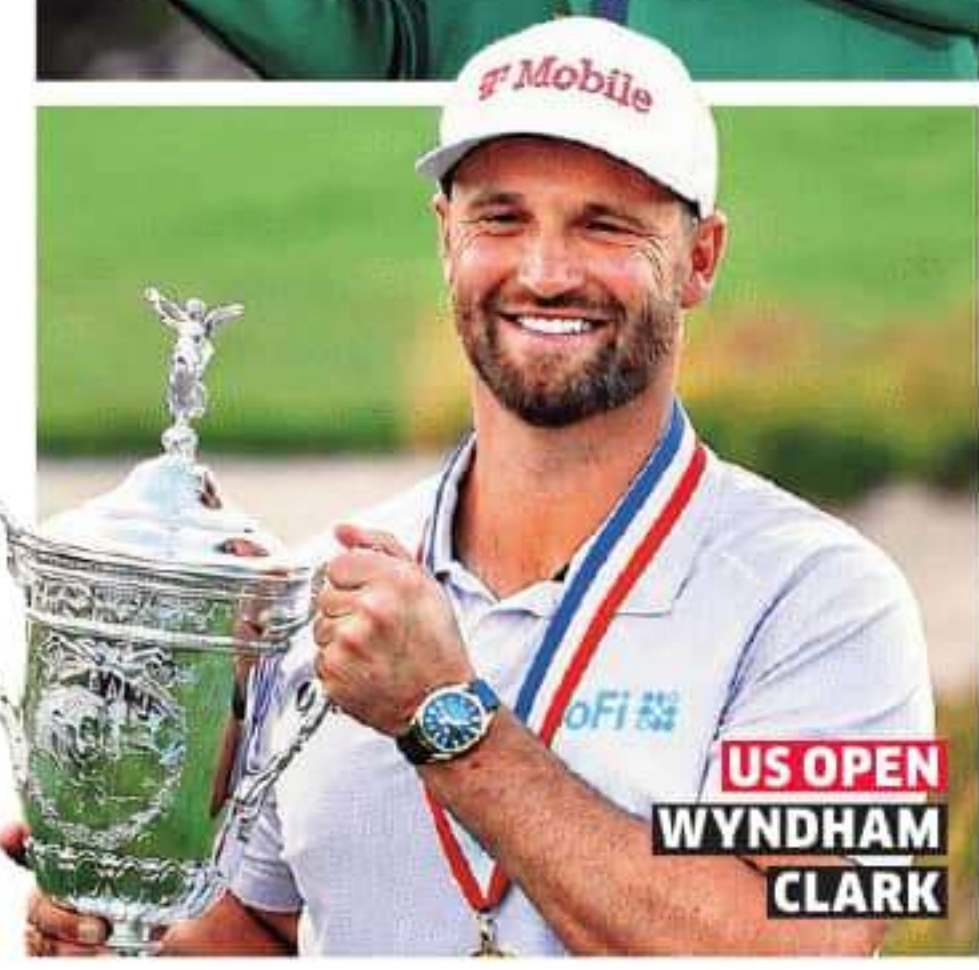
HOLE IN ONE



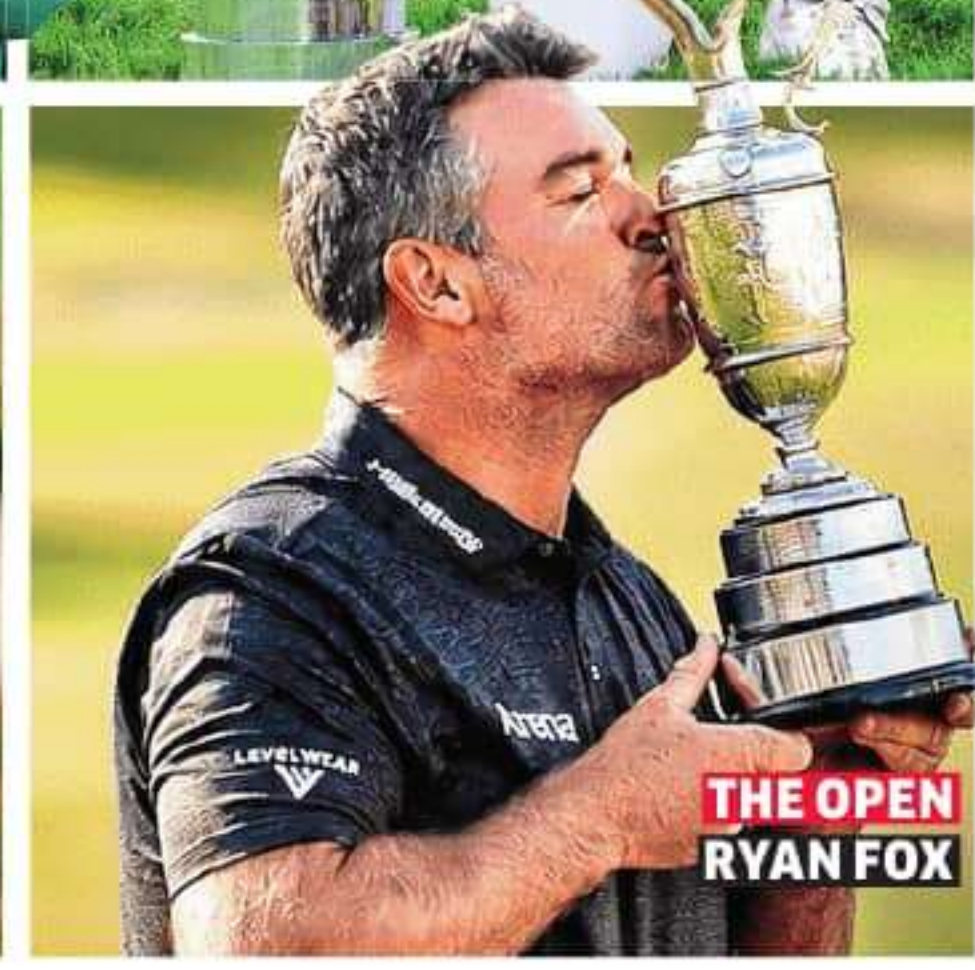
MASTERS RORY MCILROY



PGA CHAMPIONSHIP AARON RAI



US OPEN WYNDHAM CLARK



THE OPEN RYAN FOX

Instead of reconciling with LIV, the PGA Tour outflanked it. In July, the Tour and its ally the DP World Tour struck a multi-year deal with the Asian Tour. It's less a merger than an annexation, leaving LIV increasingly isolated

debate, and a firm deadline nobody entirely believes will hold.

LIV'S MONEY PROBLEM OR MANY PROBLEMS?

If the rollback is a governance failure of caution, LIV Golf's 2026 has been a governance failure of overreach. In April, Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund (PIF) announced it would stop bankrolling LIV after this season, and founding chairman Yasir Al-Rumayyan stepped down from the board. By June, the Financial Times reported LIV needed roughly \$600 mil-

lion to finish its 2026 schedule and had received barely a third of it, forcing the cancellation of a New Orleans event and the shutdown of its streaming service. CEO Scott O'Neil has been shopping for \$250 million to \$350 million in outside capital while reportedly weighing bankruptcy as a restructuring option. New PGA Tour commissioner Brian Rolapp, meanwhile, has flatly denied any merger talks are underway, telling Bloomberg: "There's no merger, no conversations".

Instead of reconciling with LIV, the PGA Tour outflanked it. In July, the Tour and its ally the DP World Tour struck a multiyear deal with the Asian Tour — the same circuit that has co-sanctioned LIV's International Series since 2022 — creating a pathway for top Asian players onto the DP World Tour and hoping that the Asian Tour will not renew with LIV. It is less a merger than an annexation, leaving LIV increasingly isolated: flush with contracted stars, short on cash, and now missing the Asian pipeline that gave its International Series relevance.

2026 delivered golf's best argument for itself — four majors, four deserving champions, a wire-to-wire thriller at Shinnecock — while its stewards spent the year proving they can neither regulate the ball nor unify the tours. The talent has never looked more compelling. The people in charge of it have rarely looked more lost.

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